

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · July 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	80.7
#2	A+	Charlotte	73.3
#3	A+	Atlanta	70.5
#4	A+	Kansas City	70.4
#5	A+	Cincinnati	69.4
#6	A+	Nashville	69.0
#7	A	Salt Lake City	65.9

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	19.7
#49	D	Louisville	20.1
#48	D	Grand Rapids	20.7
#47	C-	Chicago	28.5
#46	C-	Minneapolis	29.5
#45	C-	Detroit	30.7
#44	C-	Richmond	31.5

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	11 cities
B+ / B / B-	24 cities
C+ / C / C-	12 cities
D	3 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · July 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	80.7	3.0%	+4.2%	+2.2%	+0.6%	50 days
2	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	73.3	3.6%	+3.9%	+1.4%	+0.3%	51 days
3	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	70.5	3.2%	+4.3%	+0.0%	+1.6%	52 days
4	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	70.4	3.5%	+8.3%	+0.2%	-0.7%	45 days
5	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	69.4	3.1%	+5.4%	+0.5%	-1.0%	37 days
6	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	69.0	2.8%	+7.2%	+0.3%	-0.8%	53 days
7	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A	65.9	3.4%	+4.1%	+2.1%	-0.1%	50 days
8	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	65.4	2.7%	+3.4%	+1.9%	+2.8%	29 days
9	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A	65.0	3.5%	+1.0%	+1.5%	-0.8%	37 days
10	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	61.4	3.5%	+5.7%	+1.1%	+0.4%	N/A
11	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A-	61.3	3.8%	+6.5%	-0.5%	+2.0%	47 days
12	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B+	58.7	3.9%	+7.8%	+0.8%	-1.4%	43 days
13	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	56.2	5.3%	+5.0%	+2.1%	+1.3%	55 days
14	New York New York-Newark-Jersey City	B	53.8	4.3%	+4.5%	+0.5%	+0.5%	47 days
15	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B	53.5	4.4%	+4.2%	+1.2%	+1.1%	70 days
16	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	52.7	4.8%	+7.2%	+0.0%	-0.3%	37 days
17	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	52.1	3.6%	+6.5%	+0.3%	-1.8%	37 days
18	Cleveland Cleveland	B	51.0	3.4%	-0.3%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
19	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	50.9	4.0%	+2.1%	+0.6%	+0.2%	51 days
20	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B	50.5	3.6%	+7.5%	-0.3%	-0.9%	82 days
21	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	50.4	4.1%	-0.1%	+0.2%	+1.5%	39 days
22	Columbus Columbus	B-	49.9	2.7%	+3.6%	+0.2%	-1.5%	39 days
23	Fresno Fresno	B-	49.8	7.4%	+5.2%	+2.0%	0.0%	55 days
24	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	49.1	4.6%	+2.0%	+0.6%	+0.0%	50 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	48.5	4.8%	+4.2%	+1.8%	-1.9%	50 days
26	Memphis Memphis	B-	48.3	4.1%	+7.7%	-0.1%	-1.1%	64 days
27	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	48.2	3.2%	+0.4%	+0.6%	-0.8%	54 days
28	St. Louis St. Louis	B-	47.9	3.6%	+1.5%	-0.3%	-0.7%	44 days
29	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	45.8	4.5%	+5.9%	-0.0%	-0.3%	68 days
30	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	45.1	3.6%	+1.9%	-0.6%	-2.6%	48 days
31	Providence Providence-Warwick	B-	45.1	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	32 days
32	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	45.1	4.2%	+6.5%	-0.5%	-1.1%	51 days
33	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B-	44.4	3.9%	+4.2%	-0.7%	-0.2%	36 days
34	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	44.2	3.9%	+3.5%	-0.4%	+2.9%	37 days
35	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	44.1	4.1%	+2.5%	+1.0%	-1.3%	64 days
36	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	42.9	3.7%	+6.1%	-1.0%	-1.3%	37 days
37	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	42.8	3.2%	+1.3%	-0.9%	-0.1%	33 days
38	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	41.4	3.0%	+0.4%	-1.1%	-0.2%	45 days
39	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C+	40.4	4.6%	+5.7%	-0.1%	-2.3%	59 days
40	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	40.2	3.9%	+5.3%	-3.0%	-2.7%	36 days
41	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C	36.8	4.1%	+1.2%	+0.4%	-0.1%	61 days
42	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.4	N/A	+6.4%	-2.8%	-1.1%	51 days
43	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	34.8	4.2%	+1.2%	+0.6%	-1.5%	43 days
44	Richmond Richmond	C-	31.5	3.5%	+3.0%	-0.9%	-1.0%	37 days
45	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	30.7	5.5%	+1.7%	-0.8%	+2.2%	38 days
46	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C-	29.5	3.9%	+0.5%	+0.3%	-1.4%	37 days
47	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	28.5	4.9%	+3.6%	-0.0%	-1.7%	33 days
48	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	D	20.7	4.4%	+2.7%	-0.6%	-6.2%	33 days
49	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	D	20.1	4.6%	+1.8%	-0.8%	-1.0%	40 days
50	Jacksonville Jacksonville	D	19.7	4.7%	-0.2%	-0.4%	-0.1%	59 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

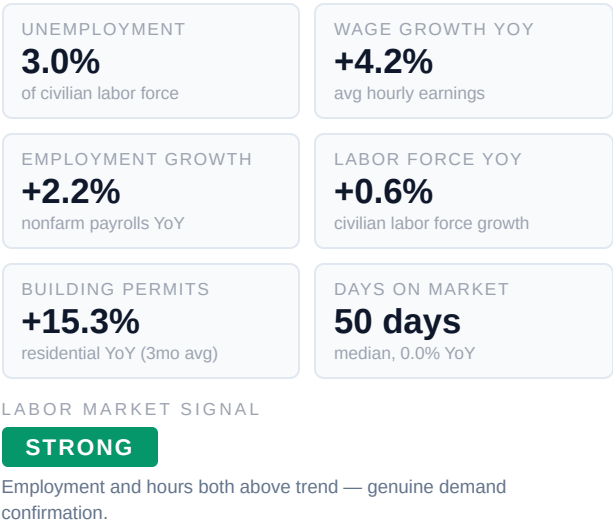
80.7th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 80.7th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 98th percentile, driven by a 2.17% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.93% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of these metrics signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating a strong and growing job market.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has seen a 2.17% year-over-year employment growth rate, paired with a 1.93% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a strong and growing job market, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 8.84 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the 98th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.00%, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 4.25%, ranking in the 58th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage growth. While this is not exceptionally high, it still suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, and workers are seeing an increase in their purchasing power. However, the moderate pace of wage growth may not be sufficient to keep up with the cost of living in the area.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score of 85th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$218/sqft to \$38.42/hr, equivalent to 5.67. The fact that the PSF is decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year makes the city more affordable relative to its peers. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing to provide large premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary has grown by 0.58% year-over-year, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is not exceptionally strong, it still suggests that the labor pool is increasing, providing businesses with a

slightly larger talent pool to draw from. However, the slow pace of growth may not be sufficient to meet the demands of a rapidly expanding job market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 15.33% year-over-year, ranking in the 76th percentile, indicating an expansion of the housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 50 days, with a 0% year-over-year change, ranking in the 29th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. The lack of change in days on market suggests that the market is maintaining its current pace, rather than experiencing a significant shift.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 98th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong job market, moderate wage growth, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and investment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively tight labor market, which can drive up labor costs and make it challenging to hire and retain top talent.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

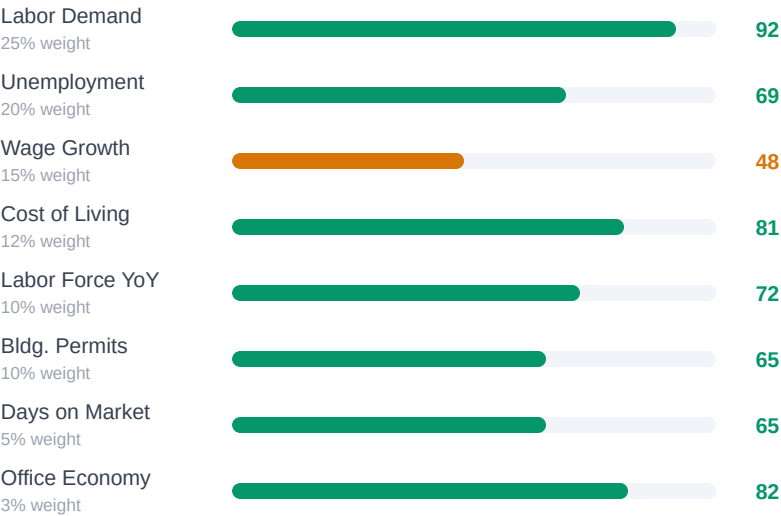
A+

EXCELLENT

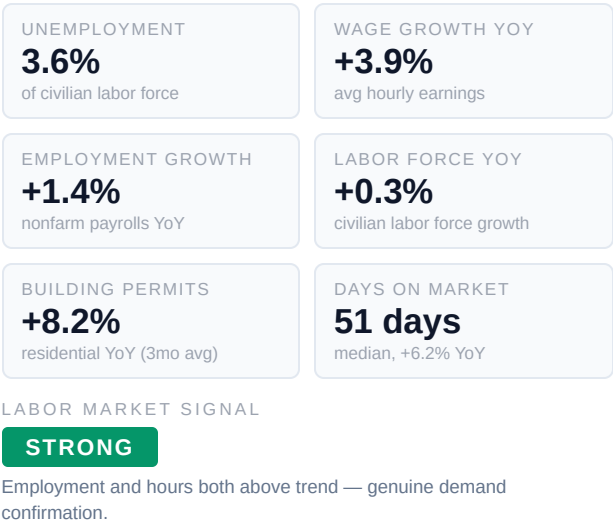
73.3th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.16, and its high office economy share, ranking in the 82nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.37% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.945% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.37% employment growth rate and a 0.945% increase in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion in the Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.16 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 3.60%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 69th. This rate indicates a relatively tight labor market, although not extremely so, suggesting that businesses may face some competition for talent but not to an extreme degree. For a business trying to hire in this market, it may be moderately challenging to find the right candidates, potentially leading to some wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.91%, placing it near the median at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are seeing a modest improvement in their purchasing power. This balance could support a stable business environment, where costs are manageable, and worker satisfaction is maintained.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$221/sqft to \$38.36/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.3% in PSF, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia ranks in the top tier for affordability at the 81st percentile. This means the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability, enhancing the city's appeal for both businesses and workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is growing at a rate of 0.32% year-over-year, indicating a modest expansion in the workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is supported by an increasing pool of potential workers, albeit at a slow pace. This slow growth may not fully keep up with demand in a rapidly expanding sector but is generally a positive sign for businesses looking to hire.

Building Permits

The city is seeing an 8.18% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce, suggesting that the city is likely to remain attractive to workers and businesses alike in terms of housing availability and costs.

Days on Market

Homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia are currently sitting on the market for a median of 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.2%. This increase in days on market, while still relatively fast, suggests a normalization of the housing market, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers. However, the market remains competitive, and workers may still face challenges in finding and securing housing quickly.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked in the 82nd percentile, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia boasts a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an excellent location for businesses in these sectors, offering access to specialized skills and knowledge. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles, where the talent pool might be less concentrated.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong economy with genuine labor demand expansion, a moderate unemployment rate, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for moderate wage pressure due to a relatively tight labor market, which could impact labor costs and the competitiveness of businesses in the area.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

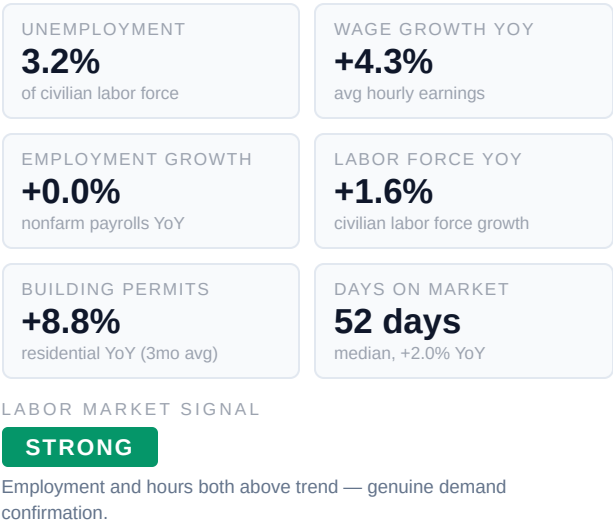
70.5th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.5th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.35, and its low unemployment rate of 3.20%, which ranks in the 78th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and a tight labor pool.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is 0.03% year-over-year, combined with a 1.004% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a shift in hours worked. As a result, businesses can expect to find a strong and growing workforce in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.20%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. With an unemployment rate ranking in the 78th percentile, the market has relatively little slack, making it a seller's market for labor.

Wage Growth

Wages in Atlanta are growing at a rate of 4.31% year-over-year, which is a moderate pace. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable rate. At the same time, workers in the area are seeing an increase in their purchasing power, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$198/sqft to \$36.88/hr, Atlanta ranks in the 73rd percentile for affordability, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The city's relatively low cost of living is a major advantage for talent attraction and retention.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of 1.58% year-over-year, which is a relatively strong pace. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, giving businesses a larger pool of potential employees to draw from. With a labor force growth rate ranking in the 86th percentile, Atlanta is well-positioned to support the hiring needs of growing businesses.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is increasing at a rate of 8.79% year-over-year, which suggests that housing supply is expanding. This is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it indicates that the city is investing in new housing stock to support its growing population. The increase in building permits is a key factor in maintaining affordability and attracting new residents.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is currently 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, with homes selling at a moderate pace. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have a relatively accessible and competitive housing market, with a range of options available.

Office Economy

With an office economy ranking in the 66th percentile, Atlanta has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting industries, which require a high concentration of skilled workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, low unemployment, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the city's tight labor market and relatively low cost of living also mean that businesses may need to be competitive in their hiring practices and wage offers to attract and retain top talent, which is the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in.

Kansas City

Kansas City

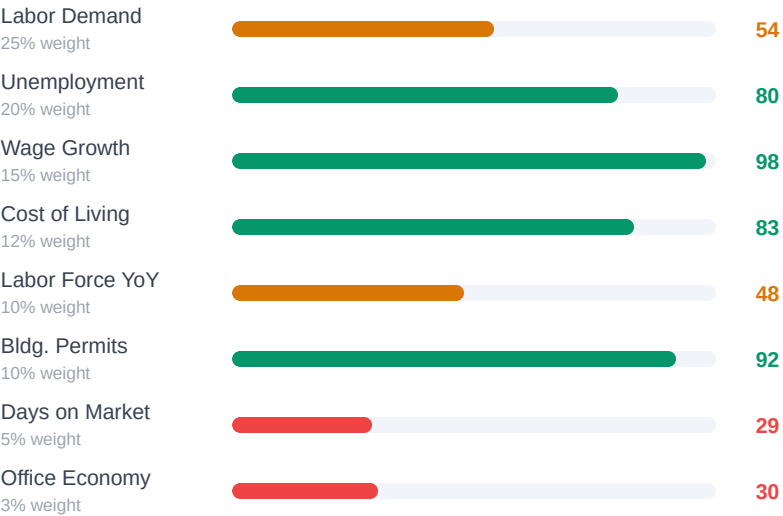
A+

EXCELLENT

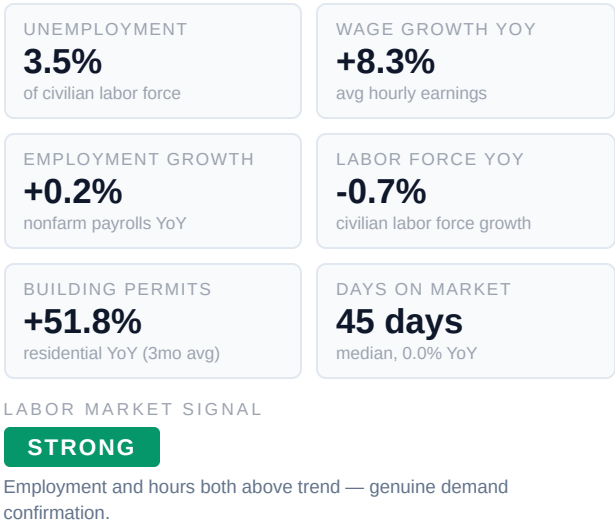
70.4th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 8.26% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 3.50%, which together signal a highly competitive labor market. These metrics suggest that Kansas City is an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 0.25% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.049% above its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.70, which is near the median. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The city's labor market is characterized by a steady increase in jobs and hours worked, indicating a stable and growing economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.50%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 80th. This low unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive job market.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 8.26%, Kansas City experiences exceptionally fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also translates to increased purchasing power for workers, making the city an attractive location for businesses that value a skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

Kansas City has a cost of living score that corresponds to a top-tier percentile rank of 83rd, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$197/sqft to \$35.77/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.51. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The stable and relatively low cost of living in Kansas City can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is shrinking at a rate of -0.70% year-over-year, which is near the median. This contraction in the labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compensate for the limited labor force growth in the city.

Building Permits

Kansas City has experienced a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of +51.78%, ranking it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This surge in building permits signals an expansion in housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in permits is a positive indicator for businesses considering relocation, as it suggests a more stable and accessible housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Kansas City is 45 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, corresponding to a below-average percentile rank of 29th. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive housing market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers. However, the stable days on market suggests a balanced market that is neither overly hot nor cold, providing a degree of predictability for businesses and their employees.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in other sectors, such as logistics or manufacturing, that can tap into its diverse workforce.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, low unemployment, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce. However, the city's shrinking labor force and competitive housing market pose significant risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Kansas City as a potential business location.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

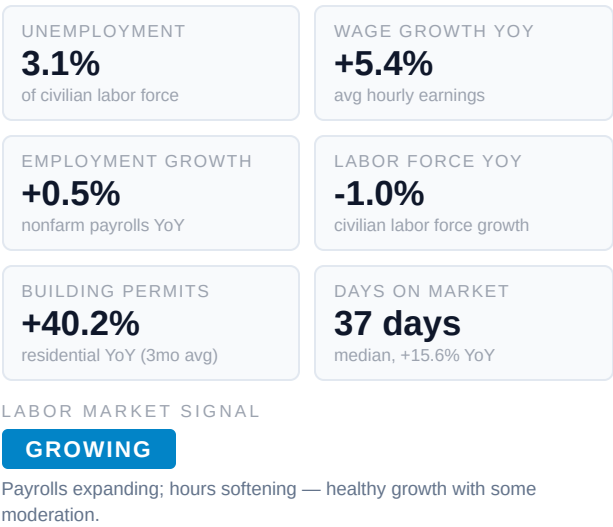
69.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 69.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and its top-tier cost of living score, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.47, indicating a highly affordable market. These metrics suggest a city with a tight labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.45% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.694% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.24, near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked slightly below trend, it may indicate some degree of survivor squeeze. The labor market is not experiencing strong genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.10%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure may be higher. Companies looking to staff up may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +5.40% year-over-year, above average, ranking at the 70th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs, but also consider the benefits of a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living score ranks at the 88th percentile, indicating a highly affordable market, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.47. The city's affordability, combined with its low unemployment rate, makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums. This is a major advantage for businesses looking to attract and retain employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking at a rate of -0.97% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cincinnati are increasing at a rate of +40.25% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in its infrastructure to support growing demand. This could help mitigate some of the pressure on the labor market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cincinnati is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +15.6%, ranking at the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share ranks at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent in these sectors. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech or finance talent. Its office economy is more geared towards a balanced mix of industries.

Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, affordable cost of living, and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to establish or grow their operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may require businesses to adopt creative strategies to attract and retain talent.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A+

EXCELLENT

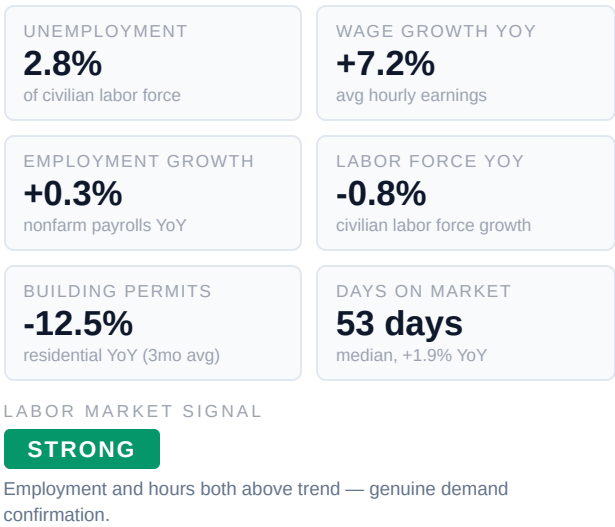
69.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 69.0th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 80th percentile, and its low unemployment rate of 2.80%, which places it in the 88th percentile. These metrics signal a highly competitive job market with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate of +0.35% year-over-year, combined with a +0.942% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicates genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.73 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.80% is exceptionally low, placing the city in the 88th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +7.21% is robust, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees can afford more goods and services. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to maintain profit margins.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.31, which is above average, and a PSF of \$260/sqft that is decreasing by -1.1% year-over-year relative to wages of \$35.58/hr, the city is relatively affordable, ranking in the 60th percentile. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.82% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -12.54%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits may signal future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.9%. This suggests a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible. Relocating workers may still find it relatively easy to find housing, but the market is not as slow as it could be.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.80, ranking in the 86th percentile, the city has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a highly competitive job market with strong labor demand and low unemployment, making it an attractive location for those willing to invest in talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the tightening housing supply, which may pose future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, making it essential for businesses to factor this into their location decision.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

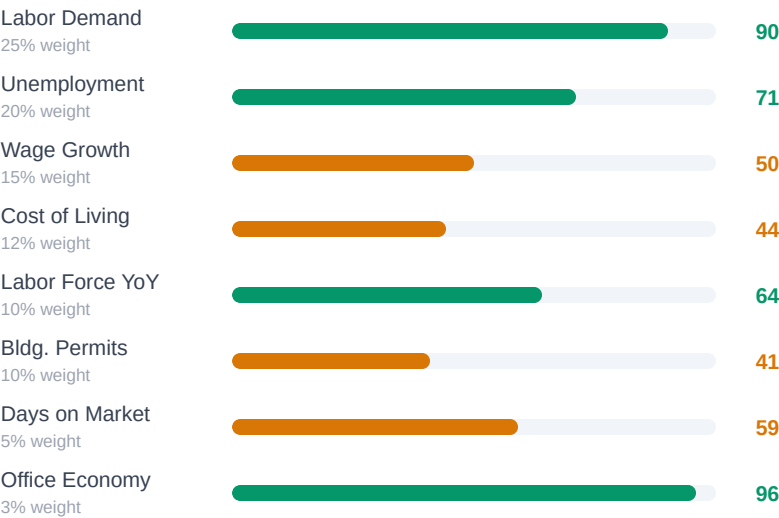
A

VERY GOOD

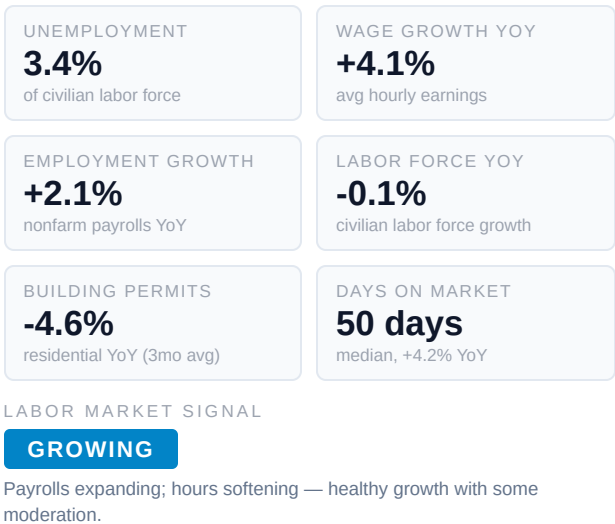
65.9th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.80, combining a 2.12% employment growth rate and a -0.467% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. The unemployment rate and office worker share are also key defining metrics, with the latter indicating a deep talent pool.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 2.12% employment growth rate year-over-year, combined with a -0.467% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, resulting in a top-tier labor demand composite score. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth, indicating a healthy labor market. The labor demand is strong, with a 90th percentile rank, suggesting a favorable environment for businesses looking to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.40%, ranking in the 71st percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with potential upward pressure on wages. However, the market is not excessively tight, allowing for some flexibility in staffing decisions.

Wage Growth

The city has experienced a 4.07% year-over-year wage growth rate, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers see a modest increase in purchasing power. The wage growth is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant, providing a relatively stable environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$266/sqft to \$38.85/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.85, Salt Lake City-Murray ranks in the 44th percentile for affordability. This near-median ranking indicates that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive, relative to its peers. The relatively moderate cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but may still face some competition for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown at a -0.06% year-over-year rate, ranking in the 64th percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the workforce is not expanding rapidly. However, the contraction is relatively mild, and businesses may still find sufficient talent to meet their needs.

Building Permits

The city has seen a -4.56% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking in the 41st percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply may be tightening, potentially leading to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. The decrease in permits may signal a future supply squeeze, which could impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 50 days, with a 4.2% year-over-year increase. This moderate days on market suggests a relatively accessible housing market for relocating workers, although the rising trend may indicate a slight slowing of the market. The near-median percentile rank of 59th indicates a balanced market, neither excessively competitive nor slow.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 4.36, ranking in the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray boasts a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses seeking specialized knowledge workers, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand environment, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively moderate cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential tightening of housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

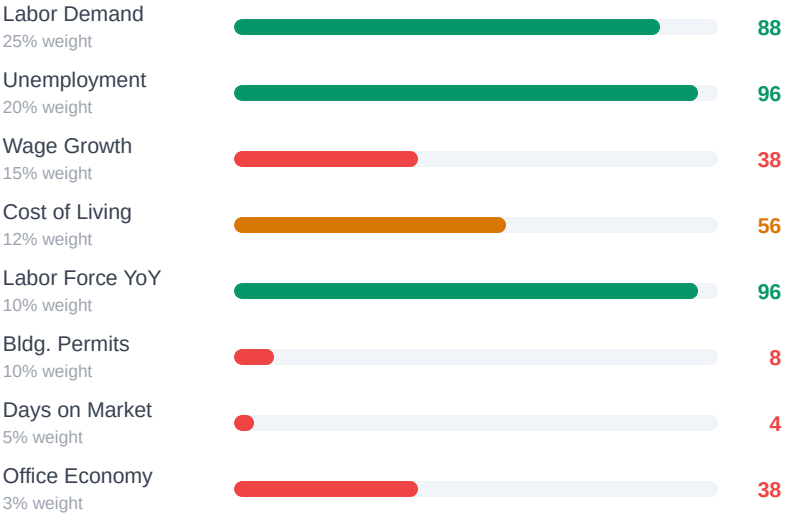
A

VERY GOOD

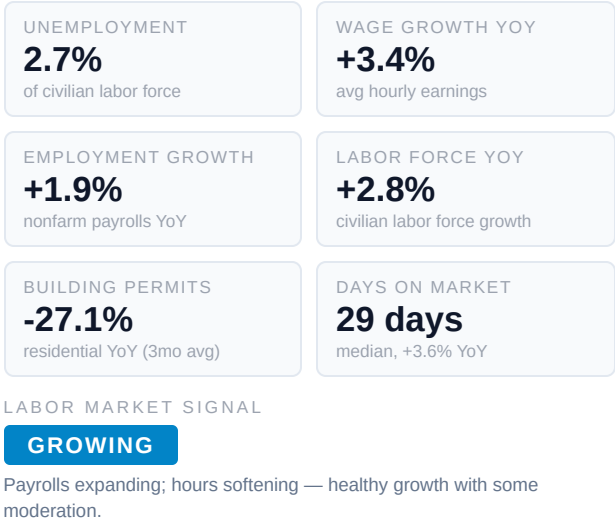
65.4th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.4th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low unemployment rate, at 2.70%. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.56 places it in the top tier, at the 88th percentile, while its unemployment rate is in the top tier, at the 96th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a robust job market and limited labor supply slack.

Labor Demand

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has seen employment growth of +1.88% year-over-year, combined with a -0.371% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend, indicating that the growth is not solely due to existing workers taking on more hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.56, in the top tier at the 88th percentile, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, placing it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the limited supply of unemployed workers will lead to upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies looking to staff up in this city should be prepared to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area is +3.35% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the relatively slow wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the low unemployment rate and tight labor market.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is near the median, with a percentile rank of 56th, and a price-to-salary ratio of 6.33, based on \$254 per square foot and \$40.12 per hour. The city's cost of living is neither extremely high nor low, but the fact that PSF is rising at +0.8% year-over-year may indicate some upward pressure on housing costs. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to affordability, and businesses may need to consider wage premiums to compensate for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, at the 96th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. However, the tight labor market and low unemployment rate may still pose challenges for companies trying to staff up.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by -27.06% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier, at the 8th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges for workforce accommodation. This could be a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain talent in the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.6%. This relatively slow market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, means that homes are sitting on the market for a longer period, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this may also indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a sign of weak demand.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.14, ranking below average, at the 38th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep bench of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, the city may still be attractive to businesses in other industries that do not rely as heavily on these specialized roles.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a strong job market with low unemployment, but also poses challenges in terms of hiring and labor costs. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges for workforce accommodation, making it essential for businesses to factor this into their location decisions and talent attraction strategies. Overall, the city's strengths in labor demand and labor force growth make it an attractive location for businesses, but the potential risks and constraints must be carefully considered.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

A

VERY GOOD

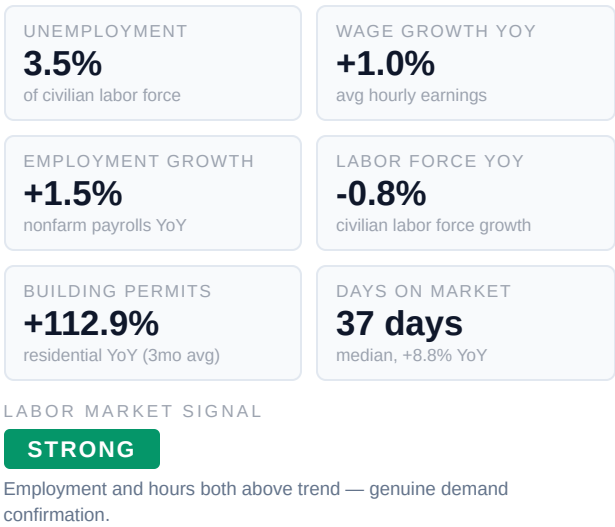
65.0th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its exceptional labor demand and building permits growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.93, combining a 1.52% employment growth rate and a 1.801% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with a top-tier ranking in building permits growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is experiencing a labor demand expansion, with a 1.52% employment growth rate and weekly hours 1.801% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand, as hours are increasing during a period of job growth, indicating that new jobs are being added and existing workers are taking on more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 3.50%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. However, this also suggests a strong local economy with low unemployment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 0.98%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth may help keep labor costs flat for employers, but it also means that workers may have weaker bargaining power and lower purchasing power. This could impact the local consumer demand and the overall attractiveness of the area for businesses relying on local spending.

Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living score ranking in the 10th percentile, with a PSF of \$813/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$55.01/hr, resulting in a ratio of 14.78. The fact that PSF is falling by 4.9% YoY is a key driver of the low affordability score, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is shrinking at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, ranking near the median. This contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 112.94% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 96th percentile. This surge in building permits signals an expansion in housing supply, which could improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find housing in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 37 days, with an 8.8% year-over-year increase. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but the rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization. For workers relocating to this city, the market may be becoming slightly more accessible, but it still remains relatively fast-paced.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 84th percentile, with a share of jobs in professional and office sectors of 3.64. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and knowledgeable workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, expanding housing supply, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech and finance sectors. However, the city's high cost of living and stagnant wage growth pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A-

GOOD

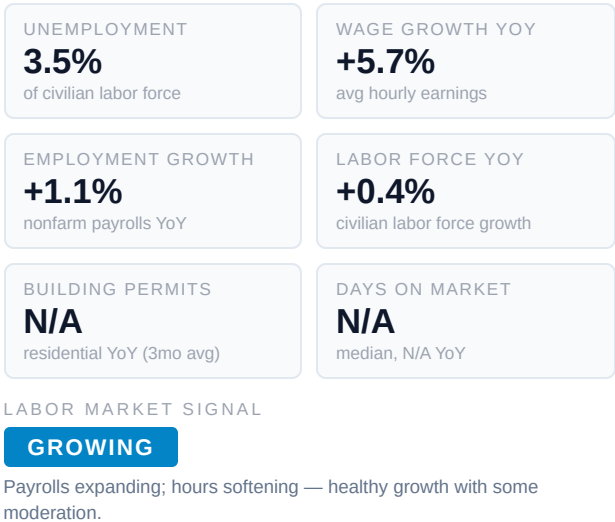
61.4th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 61.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 64th percentile, and its high office economy ranking, at the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional sectors. The labor demand and office economy metrics are particularly notable, with employment growth at 1.06% year-over-year and a high share of professional workers at 4.04 out of 5.

Labor Demand

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.06% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of -0.642% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.14, which ranks at the 64th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly below trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is absorbing new workers without significant strain. This suggests a healthy and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 3.50%, ranking at the 67th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. With an unemployment rate below the national average, businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the market has limited slack. This tight market may lead to upward pressure on wages as companies compete for scarce labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 5.67%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can drive local consumer demand. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is near the median, ranking at the 50th percentile, indicating a relatively average affordability level compared to peer cities. This means that the city neither offers a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs nor requires substantial wage premiums to offset high costs. The cost of living is not a major differentiator for this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of 0.44% year-over-year, ranking at the 74th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing.

Building Permits

Data on the year-over-year change in building permits is not available for Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos. However, this metric is crucial in understanding the future trajectory of housing supply and affordability. An increase in building permits would signal an expansion of housing supply, potentially improving affordability, while a decrease would indicate a tightening supply, potentially leading to higher housing costs.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is not available, but the city ranks at the bottom tier, or 0th percentile, indicating a very competitive market where homes sell quickly. This fast-paced market may pose challenges for relocating workers, as they may face intense competition for available housing.

Office Economy

The office economy in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is deep, with a professional and office worker share ranking at the 92nd percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, the city may be less suitable for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with a deep talent pool in professional sectors, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and finance industries. However, the city's tight labor market and rapid wage growth may pose challenges for businesses in terms of hiring and labor costs, and the competitive housing market may make it difficult for relocating workers to find affordable housing.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

A-

GOOD

61.3th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		32
Unemployment 20% weight		63
Wage Growth 15% weight		86
Cost of Living 12% weight		94
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		92
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		49
Days on Market 5% weight		22
Office Economy 3% weight		42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -0.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 47 days median, -2.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 61.3th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.54%, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.14. These metrics suggest a city with a competitive labor market and attractive living conditions.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's labor demand is characterized by a -0.49% employment growth rate and a -0.421% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, resulting in a composite score that ranks below average at the 32th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The city's labor market is not currently experiencing strong job growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, which ranks above average at the 63th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.54%, Pittsburgh is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering a location in Pittsburgh.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living is highly affordable, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.14 and a percentile rank of 94th, indicating that it is one of the most affordable cities among its peers. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.99% year-over-year, which ranks in the top tier at the 92th percentile, indicating an expanding labor supply. This growth in the labor force suggests that businesses will have a larger pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find and attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh has decreased by -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 49th percentile. This slight decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation. However, the decrease is relatively small, and the city's affordability is still a major advantage.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is currently 47 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.1%, ranking below average at the 22th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales means that workers relocating to the city may face a competitive housing market, which could make it more challenging to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 42th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent in these sectors. The city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized office or tech talent.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, highly affordable living conditions, and an expanding labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the city's relatively slow labor demand growth and tightening housing supply are potential risks that decision-makers should factor into their location decisions.

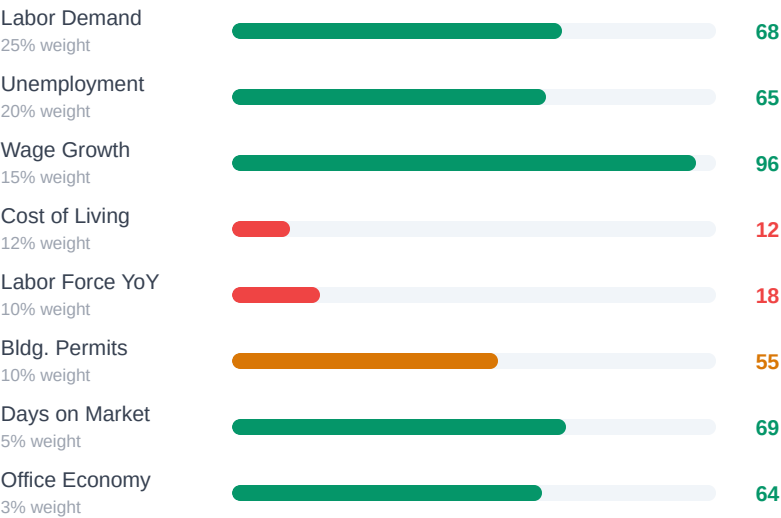
San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

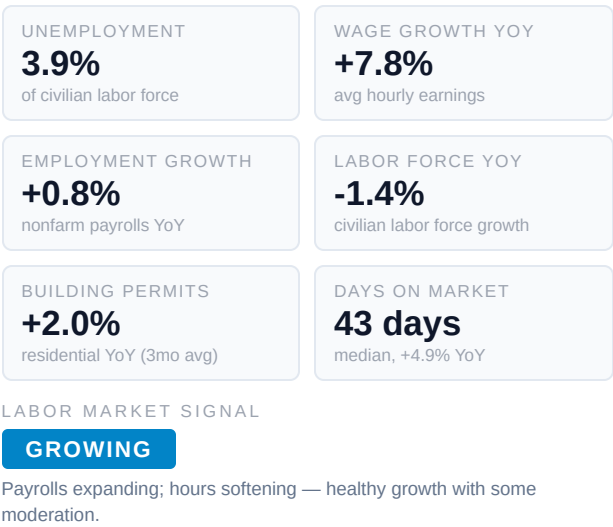
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.7th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.78% year-over-year and its above-average labor demand composite score of 5.29, which signals a genuine demand expansion. The combination of these metrics suggests a strong and growing economy.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has seen employment growth of 0.85% year-over-year, paired with a weekly hours deviation of -0.202% from its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running slightly below trend, indicating that the growth is not solely due to existing workers absorbing more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or locate in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 3.90%, ranking it at the 65th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is strong, driven by a high proportion of employed residents.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.78%, ranking it at the 96th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can drive local economic activity. Businesses should be prepared for rising labor costs, but can also benefit from the increased consumer spending power of their employees.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score ranking it at the 12th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$604/sqft to \$43.24/hr, or 13.97. However, the PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year, which slightly mitigates the affordability concerns. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living can be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking by 1.41% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This is a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding available workers to fill open positions. This contraction can limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion or relocation.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is increasing by 1.97% year-over-year, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. This is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is taking steps to address its housing needs. However, the pace of growth is not extremely rapid, so businesses should still be mindful of potential housing constraints.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.9%. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home. However, this also suggests that the housing market is not extremely competitive, which can be a positive sign for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a professional and office worker share ranking it at the 64th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less suitable for industries that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, driven by top-tier wage growth and above-average labor demand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent, and the contracting labor pool, which can limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

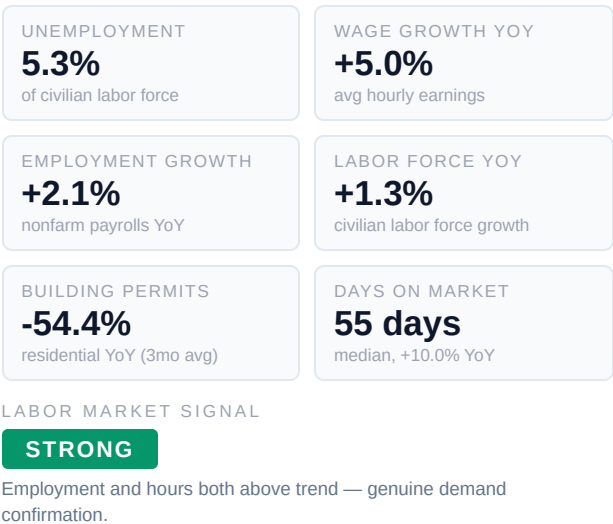
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.2th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 56.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with a composite score of 7.45, and its strong office economy, ranking at the 88th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 2.11% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.196% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.11% employment growth rate and a 0.196% increase in weekly hours above trend signals a genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in job creation and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.45, ranking at the 94th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.30%, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the local consumer demand might be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 5.01%, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth implies a balance between the need for employers to adjust their compensation packages and the benefit of workers having more disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$264/sqft to \$33.11/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.9% in PSF, this city ranks at the 52nd percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is near the median in affordability compared to its peers, suggesting that it does not particularly stand out as a talent attraction hub without wage premiums. The relatively stable cost of living makes it neither exceptionally advantageous nor disadvantageous for attracting talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of 1.33% year-over-year, ranking at the 82nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential candidates. The expanding labor force implies a reduced risk of structural hiring challenges.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -54.44%, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals a potential future affordability issue and a tightening of the housing market, which could impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce. The significant drop in building permits is a red flag for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%, ranking at the 63rd percentile. This suggests a slightly slower market, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market in the context of a strong job market could indicate a healthy normalization rather than demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas ranks at the 88th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that rely on a knowledgeable and specialized workforce, but may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the sharp decline in residential building permits, which signals potential future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

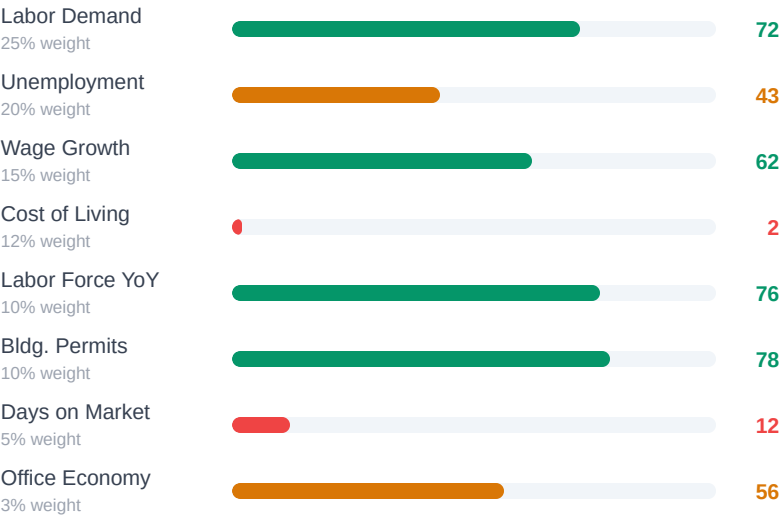
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AVERAGE

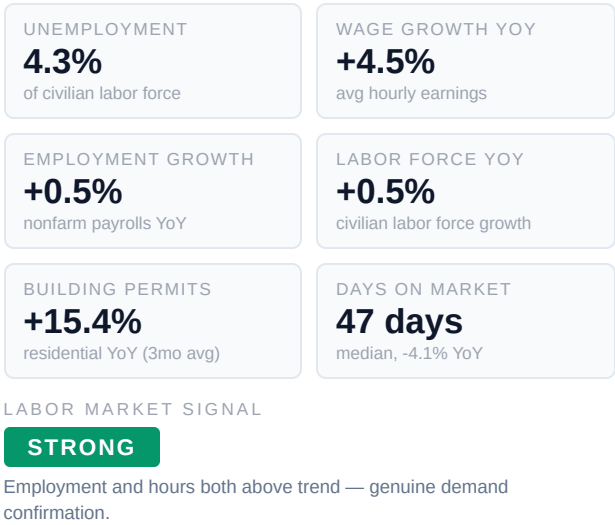
53.8th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 53.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.40, combining a +0.48% employment growth rate and a +0.430% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its labor force growth rate of +0.45% YoY indicates an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.48% YoY and a weekly hours deviation of +0.430% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above the trend line, suggesting that employers are increasing their workforce and workload. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.30%, ranking near the median at the 43rd percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack, which means that businesses may face moderate competition for talent, but still have access to a sizable pool of potential employees. As a result, hiring in this market may require some effort, but it is not excessively challenging.

Wage Growth

The YoY wage growth rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is +4.50%, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This rate indicates moderate to fast wage growth, which may lead to rising labor costs for employers, but also contributes to strong worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a skilled and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a cost of living ratio of \$537/sqft to \$40.69/hr, with a PSF increase of +3.3% YoY, ranking at the 2nd percentile in terms of affordability. This low percentile rank indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering higher salaries to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is growing at a rate of +0.45% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the labor pool is increasing, providing businesses with a larger talent pool to draw from. As a result, companies looking to expand their workforce may find it easier to do so in this market.

Building Permits

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has seen a +15.42% YoY increase in residential building permits, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This increase suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which may lead to better affordability and workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may expect a more stable and predictable housing market, which can support their growth plans.

Days on Market

The median days on market in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is currently 47 days, with a -4.1% YoY decrease, ranking at the 12th percentile. This low percentile rank indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or flexible housing options to support their employees.

Office Economy

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an office economy percentile rank of 56th, indicating a deep professional talent pool, suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized office skills, but may be less suitable for companies with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant operations. As a result, businesses in the professional services sector may find it an attractive location, with access to a skilled and experienced workforce.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand, labor force growth, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the professional services sector. However, the city's high cost of living and relatively fast-paced housing market may pose challenges for talent attraction and relocation, which businesses should carefully consider when making location decisions. Overall, the city's strengths make it a viable option for businesses looking to establish or expand operations, but its weaknesses require careful planning and consideration.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B

AVERAGE

53.5th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		86
Unemployment 20% weight		12
Wage Growth 15% weight		52
Cost of Living 12% weight		77
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		80
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		4
Days on Market 5% weight		29
Office Economy 3% weight		90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +1.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -29.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 70 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.45, combining a 1.22% employment growth rate and a 0.442% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its high share of professional and office workers, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.22% and weekly hours deviation of 0.442% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.45, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers in this city, as there is a larger pool of available labor. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.17% is near the median, ranking at the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. The moderate wage growth implies a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$224/sqft to \$33.76/hr, and a PSF decrease of 3.0% YoY, the city ranks in the 77th percentile for affordability, indicating a relatively affordable market. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work here without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.11% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the labor pool is increasing. Businesses can expect to find a growing number of potential workers in this market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -29.77%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the city may face future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 70 days, with a 0% year-over-year change, ranking below average at the 29th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for homebuyers, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and purchase homes quickly. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not overheating, and workers may still find affordable options.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with a share of office and professional workers ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a deep office economy, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially offsetting the city's other advantages.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

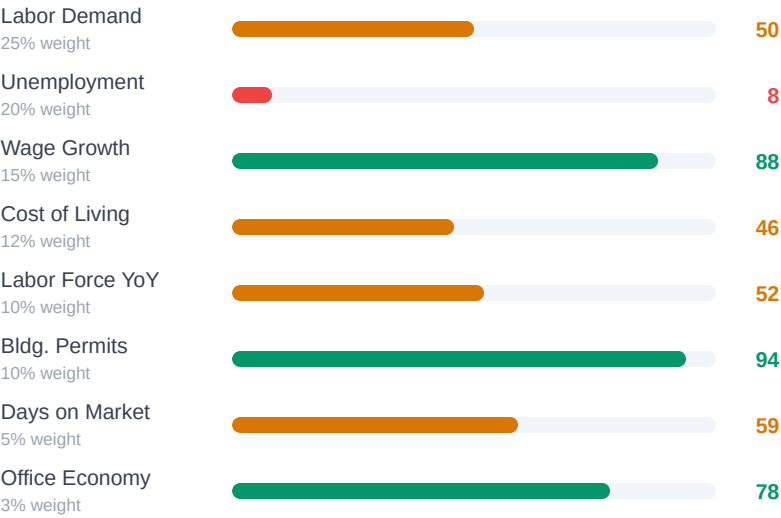
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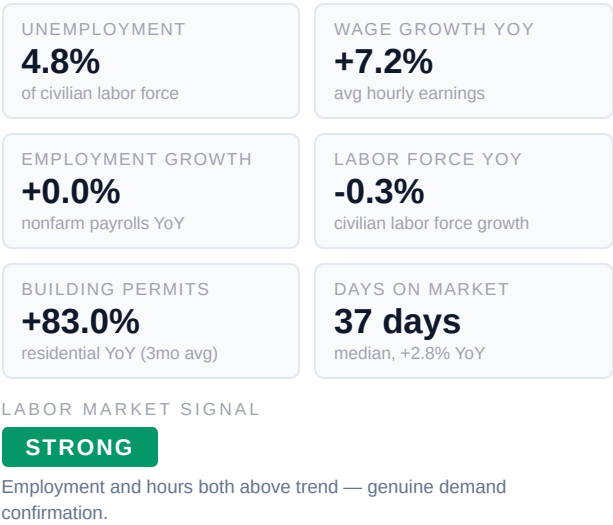
52.7th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 52.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of strengths and weaknesses. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth, at 7.21% year-over-year, and its strong building permits growth, at 83.04% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy and increasing housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.04% year-over-year, combined with a 0.263% deviation in weekly hours above the city's own trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.62 is near the median, indicating a stable but not exceptionally strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.80%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power, making it essential for employers to offer competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 7.21%, ranking at the 88th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees can afford more goods and services with their increasing earnings. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score with a PSF of \$444/sqft, which is decreasing by 3.5% year-over-year, and an earnings ratio of \$47.70/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.31, ranking at the 46th percentile. This means that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither exceptionally expensive nor unusually affordable. The decreasing PSF trend is a positive factor, but the overall affordability score does not provide a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is growing at a rate of -0.29% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in employee retention programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 83.04%, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which may lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.8%. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but not extremely fast-paced. Workers relocating to this city may find it accessible, but not overly slow, allowing for a reasonable amount of time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has an office economy score ranking at the 78th percentile, indicating a deep and specialized talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented profiles.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing economy, increasing housing supply, and a deep talent pool in professional sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and resulting wage pressure, which may impact businesses' ability to hire and retain workers without offering competitive compensation packages.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

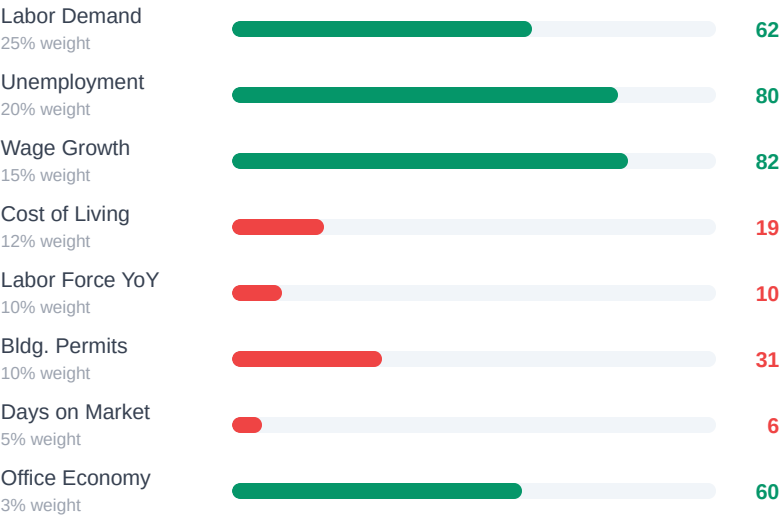
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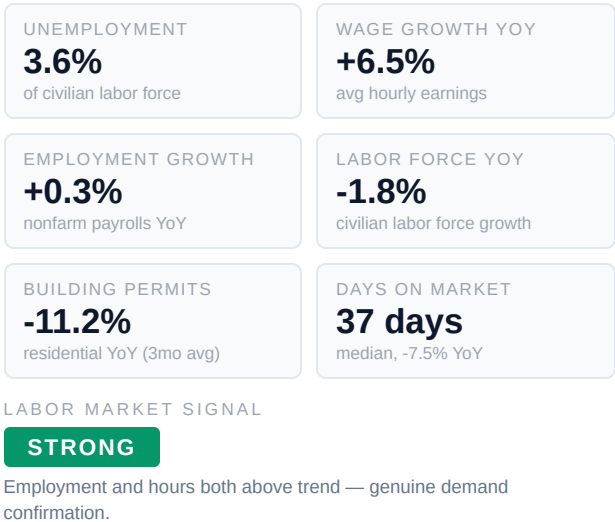
52.1th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low unemployment rate, at 3.60% and a top-tier wage growth of 6.51%. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, indicating a tight labor market with rising wages. With an employment growth rate of 0.28% and weekly hours 0.421% above trend, the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.28% and weekly hours deviation of 0.421% above trend signal genuine demand expansion in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.11, ranking in the 62th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.60% is relatively low, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.51% is relatively high, ranking in the 82th percentile, indicating fast-rising wages. This suggests that employer labor costs are increasing, but workers also have more purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. The strong wage growth may also attract more skilled workers to the area.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is relatively high, with a percentile rank of 19, due to a PSF of \$649/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$50.06, resulting in a ratio of 12.96. Although the PSF is falling by 4.1% YoY, the city remains expensive, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may be a constraint for businesses that are sensitive to labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.81% year-over-year, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is decreasing, which may exacerbate hiring challenges and create a structural headwind for businesses looking to expand. The declining labor force growth may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -11.22%, ranking in the 31st percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, which could impact workforce accommodation and attraction. The decline in building permits may signal a future supply squeeze, making it more challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -7.5%, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a fast-paced and competitive housing market. This suggests that workers relocating to the city may face challenges in finding affordable housing, as homes are selling quickly. The fast-paced market may make it difficult for businesses to attract talent, as relocating workers may struggle to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.00, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's office economy is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers, but may be less suitable for industries that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, but the high cost of living and tightening housing supply may pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive housing market and shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth and require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract and retain talent.

Cleveland

Cleveland

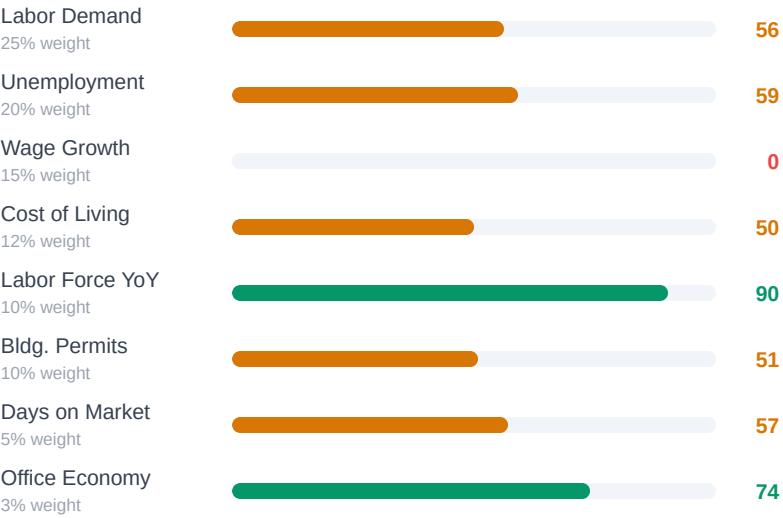
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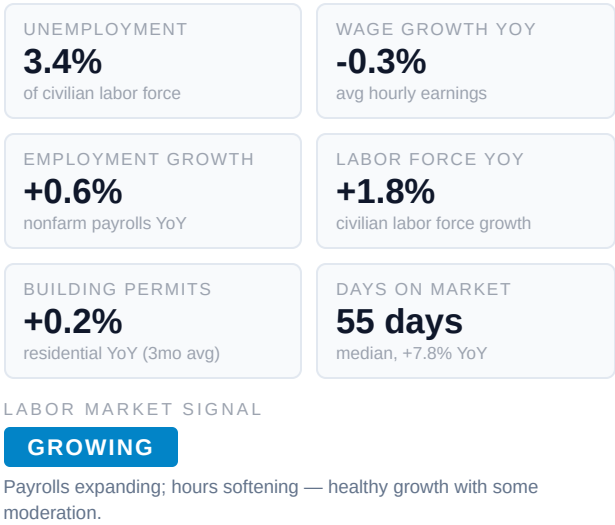
51.0th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B, ranking at the 51.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of median and top-tier performances across key metrics. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand, with a composite score of 4.71, and its top-tier labor force growth of 1.80% YoY. Notably, the labor demand is influenced by a +0.57% employment growth rate and a -0.388% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's labor demand is characterized by a +0.57% employment growth rate and a -0.388% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near-median performance. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers, albeit with hours worked slightly below the city's own 12-month baseline, suggesting some degree of labor market slack. The labor demand composite score of 4.71 reflects this balanced but not outstanding performance.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland stands at 3.40%, placing it near the median among its peers at the 59th percentile. This rate indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being overly tight, which means businesses may find it somewhat easier to hire compared to cities with lower unemployment rates. However, this also implies that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Cleveland experiences a -0.33% year-over-year change in average hourly earnings, ranking at the bottom tier or 0th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, which can be beneficial for controlling expenses but indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$143/sqft to \$33.79/hr, Cleveland ranks at the 50th percentile in terms of affordability, indicating a near-median performance. The city's cost of living is neither exceptionally high nor low compared to its peers, meaning it does not particularly stand out as a talent attraction hub without offering wage premiums. The PSF has increased by 13.5% YoY, which does not help in improving affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% YoY, placing it in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This significant expansion in the labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which is a positive indicator for

businesses looking to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

Cleveland sees a +0.17% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile. This slight increase in building permits indicates a modest expansion in future housing supply, which could help in maintaining or improving affordability and accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a +7.8% YoY increase, placing it near the median at the 57th percentile. This increase in days on market suggests a slightly slower pace in the housing market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing, as the market is not as competitive as those with rapidly selling homes.

Office Economy

Cleveland's share of jobs in professional and office sectors ranks at the 74th percentile, indicating a deeper than average talent pool in these areas. This makes the city more suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce, but less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers a balanced economic environment with notable strengths in labor force growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to consider is the stagnant wage growth, which, while beneficial for controlling labor costs, may indicate underlying challenges in the local economy and limited consumer purchasing power.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B

AVERAGE

50.9th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		66
25% weight		
Unemployment		35
20% weight		
Wage Growth		30
15% weight		
Cost of Living		75
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		70
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		16
10% weight		
Days on Market		51
5% weight		
Office Economy		94
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -16.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 51 days median, +2.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 50.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.21, combining a +0.57% employment growth rate and a +0.116% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of \$202/sqft and hourly earnings of \$36.94, resulting in a ratio of 5.47, ranks in the 75th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.57% and weekly hours deviation of +0.116% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of growth, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.21, ranking in the 66th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.00% is below average, ranking in the 35th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available to fill open positions. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.07% is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. While this may help keep costs under control, it also means that workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$202/sqft and hourly earnings of \$36.94, resulting in a ratio of 5.47, ranks in the 75th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to recruit talent without having to offer significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.4% YoY further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.19% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, albeit at a moderate pace. While this growth is positive, it may not be sufficient to meet the demands

of rapidly expanding businesses.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -16.94%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased competition for available housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.0%. This indicates a relatively balanced market, where homes are selling at a moderate pace. For workers relocating to the city, this means that the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible, providing a relatively stable environment for finding a home.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 4.18, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized skills and expertise. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B

AVERAGE

50.5th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		38
25% weight		
Unemployment		43
20% weight		
Wage Growth		92
15% weight		
Cost of Living		25
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		38
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		84
10% weight		
Days on Market		26
5% weight		
Office Economy		70
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +20.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 82 days median, -1.2% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 50.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its 7.46% year-over-year wage growth and 20.81% increase in building permits, indicating a dynamic labor market and expanding housing supply. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy, but also with some challenges in labor demand and cost of living.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.30% year-over-year, combined with a -0.119% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks below average, in the 38th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.60%, ranking near the median in the 43rd percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. This rate suggests that businesses may face moderate competition for talent, but without extreme wage pressure. The practical implication is that hiring may be manageable, but not exceptionally easy or hard.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.46%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increased worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand. The high wage growth rate suggests a competitive labor market where employers must offer attractive compensation packages.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score that ranks below average, in the 25th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$357/sqft to \$34.29/hr, equal to 10.41. Although the PSF is falling by 1.1% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging, as the cost of living is a significant factor in relocation decisions.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is contracting at a rate of -0.93% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential employees is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from a diminishing pool.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has increased by 20.81% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth suggests that future affordability may improve, and the city may become more attractive to relocating workers. The increase in building permits is a positive indicator for businesses concerned about workforce accommodation and housing costs.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 82 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.2%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, although the decrease in days on market is modest. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be somewhat competitive, but still accessible, with homes selling at a moderate pace.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking above average, in the 70th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles. The strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses seeking specialized knowledge workers.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, expanding housing supply, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living and contracting labor force, which may require businesses to offer competitive compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

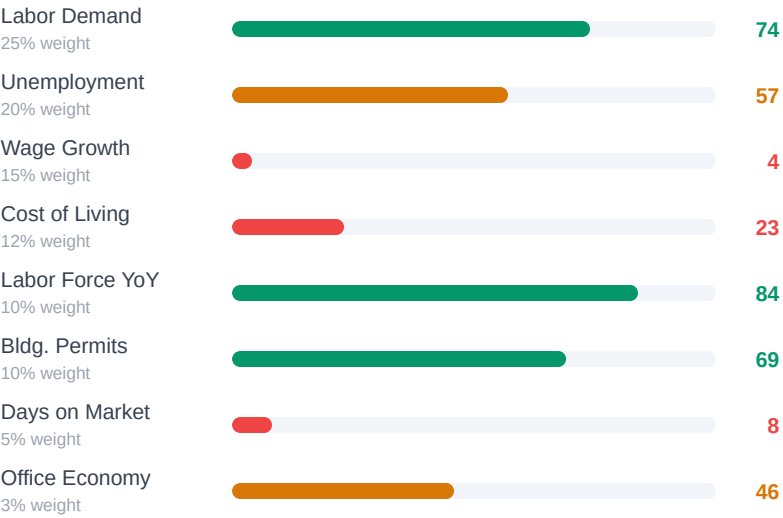
B

AVERAGE

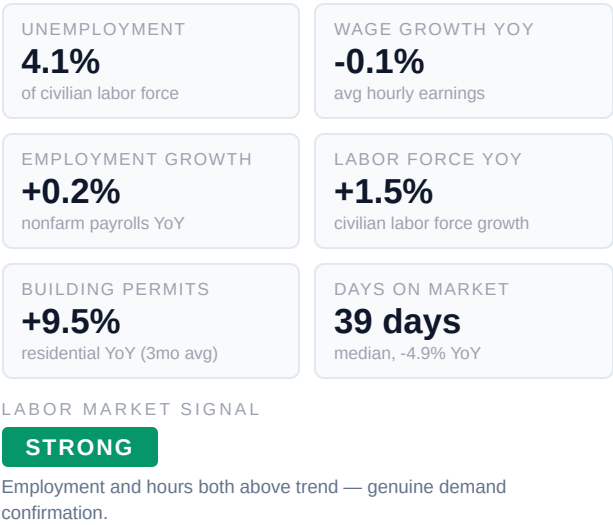
50.4th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and labor force growth metrics, which stand at 74th percentile and 84th percentile, respectively. The city's labor demand is characterized by a 0.19% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.039% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. These numbers suggest a city with genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.19% and weekly hours deviation of 1.039% above trend signal a genuine demand expansion in the Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in both the number of jobs and the hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.61, ranking at the 74th percentile, further reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington stands at 4.10%, placing it near the median at the 57th percentile. This rate suggests a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight, which means businesses may find it somewhat easier to hire workers without facing extreme wage pressure. However, the market is not so loose that it indicates weak consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is -0.06%, ranking at the 4th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a flat cost environment, but it may also reflect underlying economic conditions that are not conducive to strong consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living score that places it at the 23rd percentile, with a PSF of \$232/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.67/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.10. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 0.4% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This relatively low affordability score means the city is less competitive in terms of cost of living compared to its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area is growing at a rate of 1.49% year-over-year, ranking at the 84th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has increased by 9.53% year-over-year, placing it at the 69th percentile. This rise in building permits signals that housing supply is expected to expand, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce, making the city more attractive for relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in the metro area is 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.9%. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also suggests a strong demand for housing, which can be a sign of a vibrant local economy.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington places it at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these areas. This makes the city suited for businesses that rely on a knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, and consulting firms, but it may not be as competitive for industries that require a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a combination of growing labor demand and an expanding workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the stagnant wage growth, which could indicate underlying economic conditions that may not support strong consumer spending and could limit the bargaining power of workers, potentially affecting the overall competitiveness of the city.

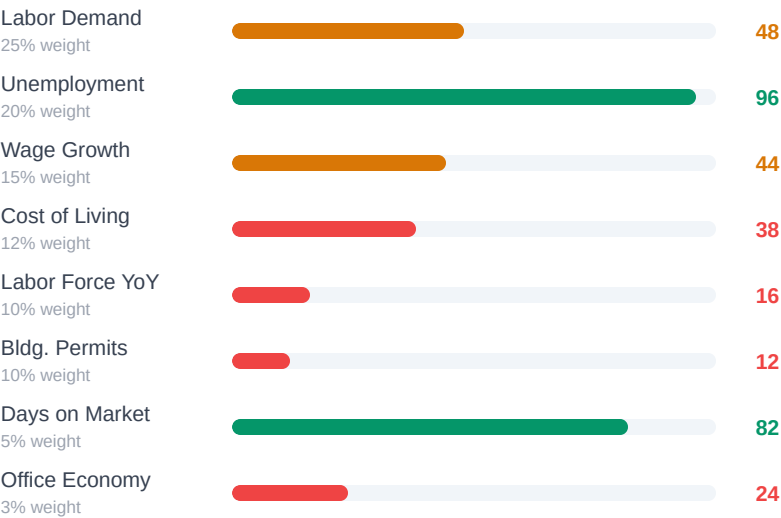
Columbus

Columbus

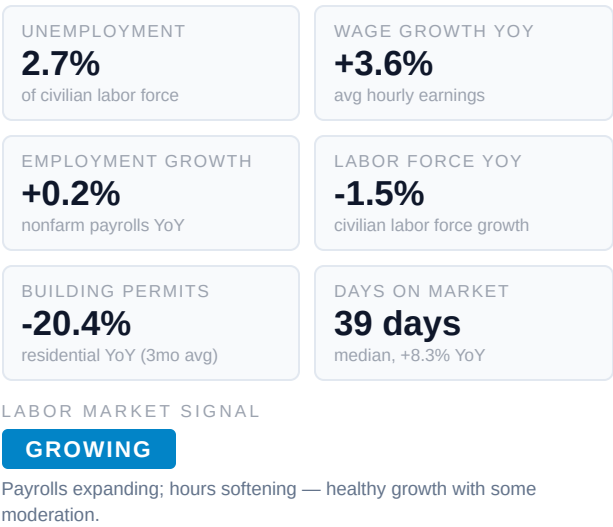
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.9th percentile
Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 49.9th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 2.70% and a labor demand composite score of 4.60, which is near the median at the 48th percentile. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate labor demand. Specifically, the combination of a low unemployment rate and near-median labor demand signals a scenario where businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the tight market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.23% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.025%, indicating a near-median labor demand. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend during job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.60 further supports this assessment, suggesting that while there is some demand for labor, it is not exceptionally strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 2.70%, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile, which means the market is very tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Columbus is +3.58%, which is near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not exceptionally quickly. Workers in Columbus are seeing their purchasing power increase, but at a pace that is not outpacing the national average.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 38th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$208/sqft to \$34.02/hr, or 6.11. This indicates that the city is less affordable than many of its peers. The fact that PSF is rising by +1.0% year-over-year relative to wages further contributes to its below-average affordability score. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's cost of living is a disadvantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.50% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is

decreasing. This trend poses a significant challenge for companies looking to expand their workforce in the city.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Columbus is decreasing by -20.36% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits signals that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend is a concern for businesses that rely on a stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Columbus is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.3%, ranking it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to Columbus, this slower market could be beneficial, as it may provide more time to find a suitable home and negotiate a better price.

Office Economy

Columbus has an office economy score that ranks it at the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent, but may be more appropriate for industries with less specialized labor needs. The city's economy is more industrial or logistics-dominant, which may appeal to certain types of businesses.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a tight labor market with moderate labor demand, which can be both a challenge and an opportunity. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may limit the city's ability to accommodate growing workforces and pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention.

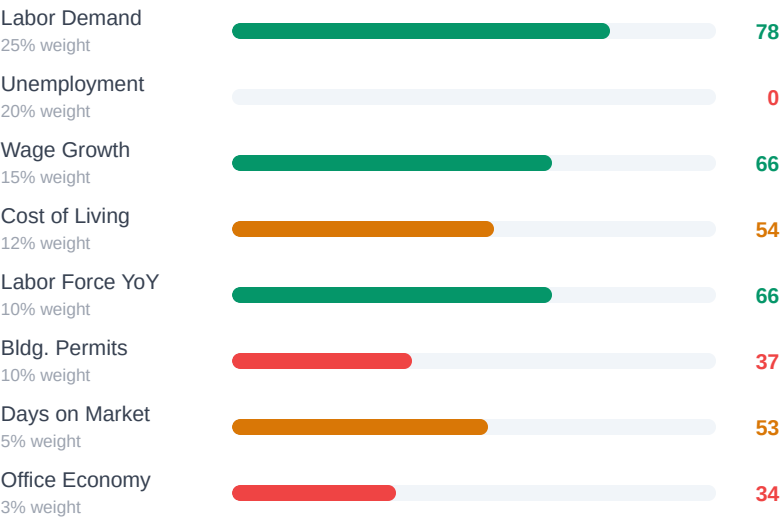
Fresno

Fresno

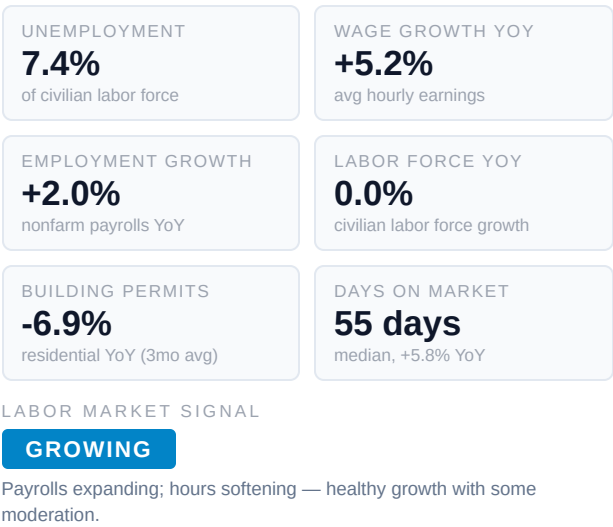
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.8th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.8th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with a composite score ranking at the 78th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which is at the bottom tier with a 0th percentile rank. Specifically, Fresno's employment growth rate of 2.04% and weekly hours deviation of -1.744% indicate a strong labor market.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate of 2.04% and weekly hours deviation of -1.744% signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are running below trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is strong, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in fewer hours than expected. The labor demand composite score of 5.66 ranks at the 78th percentile, further supporting the notion of a robust labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.40%, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a loose labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Fresno may find it easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the high unemployment rate. The low unemployment percentile rank suggests that the city's labor market is not tight, giving employers more flexibility in hiring.

Wage Growth

Fresno's year-over-year wage growth rate is 5.16%, ranking at the 66th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. The wage growth rate suggests that businesses in Fresno may face rising labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Fresno's cost of living, with a PSF of \$263/sqft and an hourly earnings rate of \$33.46, resulting in a ratio of 7.86, ranks at the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. This means that Fresno is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent. The city's affordability level is relatively stable, with a 0.0% year-over-year change in PSF.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of 0.00% year-over-year, ranking at the 66th percentile, indicating a stable labor force supply. This means that the workforce supply is neither expanding nor contracting significantly, and businesses may not face significant

structural headwinds or tailwinds in hiring. The stable labor force growth rate suggests that Fresno's labor market is not experiencing significant changes in supply.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, ranking at the 37th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is weakening, and future housing supply may not be expanding, potentially leading to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decline in building permits signals a potential risk for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.8%, ranking at the 53rd percentile. This indicates a relatively stable housing market, neither extremely competitive nor accessible, for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a normalization of the housing market, but may not significantly impact relocating workers.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share ranks at the 34th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This means that Fresno is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The city of Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market and a loose labor market with significant slack, making it easier to hire but potentially facing weaker consumer demand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in Fresno is the potential affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce due to the declining building permits and tightening housing supply.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.1th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		60
Unemployment 20% weight		22
Wage Growth 15% weight		28
Cost of Living 12% weight		92
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		68
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		14
Days on Market 5% weight		76
Office Economy 3% weight		80

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -18.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, +8.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.06, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 92th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 0.61% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.091% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.61% and the hours deviation of -0.091% signal a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running slightly below trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is experiencing a moderate expansion, with employers adding jobs but not yet pushing workers to absorb significantly more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.06 is above average, ranking at the 60th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.60% is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face moderate competition for talent, and wage pressure may be present but not extreme. The tight market implies that employers may need to offer competitive wages to attract and retain workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.01% is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile, indicating stagnant to moderate wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The moderate wage growth implies a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living is highly affordable, with a percentile rank of 92, driven by a PSF of \$172/sqft that is decreasing by 2.3% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of \$36.50/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.71. This affordability means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, providing a competitive advantage in talent attraction.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.03% year-over-year, indicating a slow expansion of the workforce supply. This slow growth implies that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers, particularly in specialized fields.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -18.95%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This tightening of housing supply signals potential future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, which may impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.7%, indicating a slowing market. This means that workers relocating to this city may find a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 80, indicating a strong presence of professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and highly affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially impacting the city's competitiveness in attracting and retaining talent.

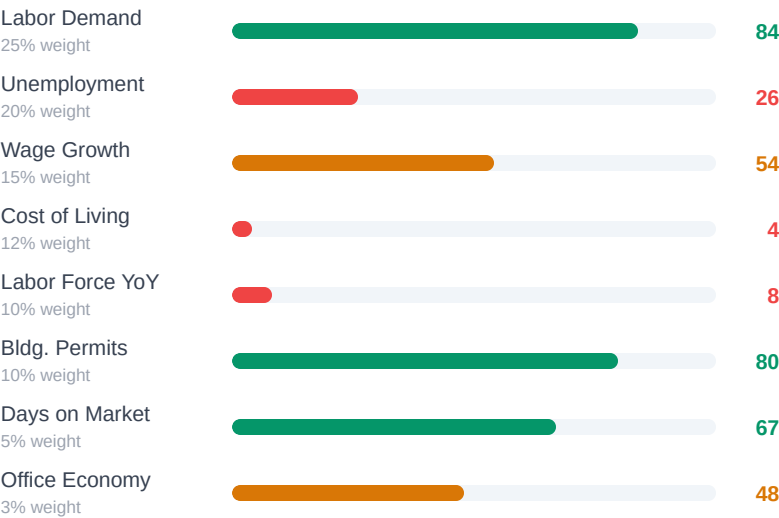
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

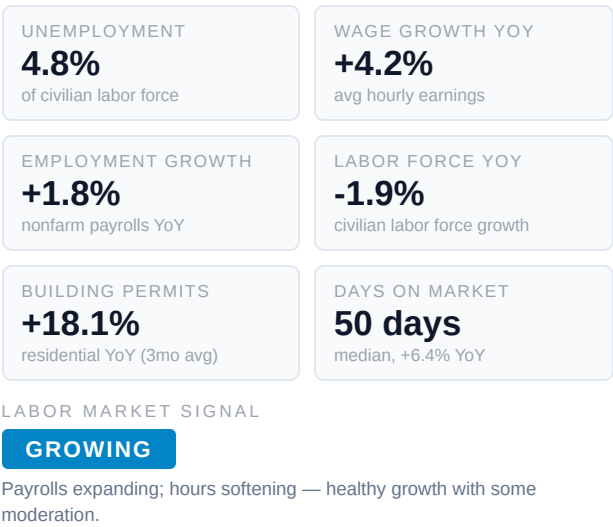
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.5th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 48.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an employment growth rate of 1.83% and a labor demand composite score in the top tier at the 84th percentile, as well as its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 15.98, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing job market but significant affordability challenges.

Labor Demand

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.83% and weekly hours 0.627% below its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion despite some giveback in hours worked. This combination signals that the job market is growing, but at a pace that allows for some normalization in work hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.23 further reinforces this interpretation, placing the city in the top tier at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim stands at 4.80%, which ranks in the below-average tier at the 26th percentile. This indicates a market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight, suggesting that businesses may find it somewhat easier to hire here compared to cities with lower unemployment rates. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 4.18%, placing it near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming pace, while workers see a decent increase in their purchasing power. This balance could support a stable business environment.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 15.98 (\$662/sqft vs \$41.42/hr), indicating that the city is expensive relative to peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.5% YoY slightly mitigates this, but the city remains challenging for talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face

increasing difficulty in finding qualified candidates.

Building Permits

The city saw an 18.09% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 80th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim currently sit on the market for a median of 50 days, with a 6.4% year-over-year increase, placing the city above average at the 67th percentile. This slightly slower market could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing, although it still represents a relatively fast-paced market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area places it near the median at the 48th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less ideal for industries requiring a large workforce in industrial or logistics sectors.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a growing job market with moderate wage growth, which can support a stable business environment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's high cost of living and contracting labor force, which may necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, posing a significant challenge for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in this area.

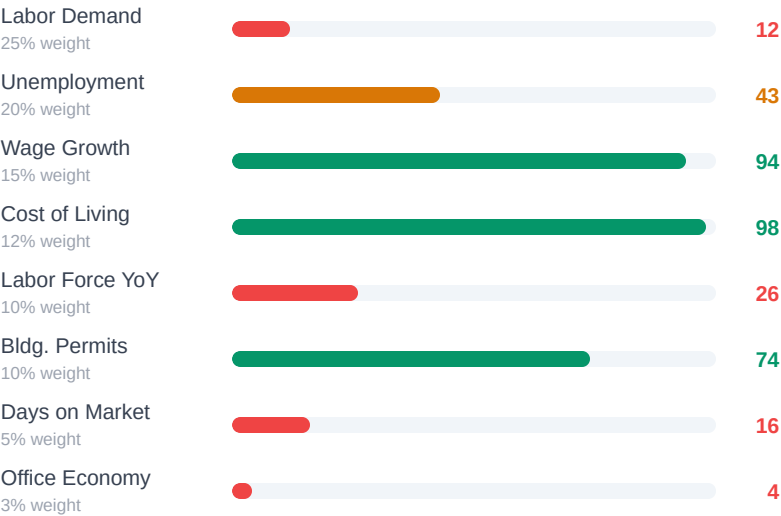
Memphis

Memphis

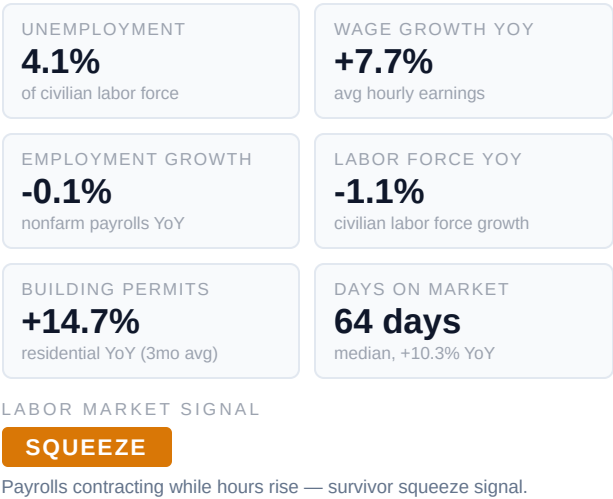
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.3th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 48.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its unique combination of strong wage growth and an affordable cost of living, with a cost of living percentile rank of 98th. The city's wage growth rate of 7.68% YoY and cost of living ratio of \$155/sqft to \$33.25/hr, with PSF falling 6.1% YoY, are the two metrics that most define its current economic character. These numbers suggest a city with rising labor costs but also attractive affordability for workers.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.11% YoY and weekly hours 1.092% above its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.05, which ranks in the bottom tier at 12th percentile. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The negative employment growth rate indicates a contracting job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.10%, ranking near the median at 43rd percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This means that while it's not extremely difficult to hire, there is some wiggle room for businesses to find talent without excessive wage pressure. However, the market is not so loose that it would lead to weak consumer demand.

Wage Growth

With a YoY wage growth rate of 7.68%, Memphis experiences fast wage growth, ranking in the top tier at 94th percentile. This implies rising labor costs for employers but also strong purchasing power for workers, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer spending. The rapid wage growth may pressure businesses to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Memphis is very affordable, with a cost of living percentile rank of 98th, due to its PSF of \$155/sqft falling 6.1% YoY relative to wages of \$33.25/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.66. This high affordability ranking means the city has a significant talent attraction advantage without needing wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand without breaking the bank on salaries.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -1.15% YoY, ranking below average at 26th percentile. This contraction in labor supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent due to this declining labor force.

Building Permits

Memphis has seen a YoY increase in building permits of 14.68%, ranking above average at 74th percentile. This rise in permits indicates that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the housing needs of their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Memphis is 64 days, with a YoY increase of 10.3%, ranking in the bottom tier at 16th percentile. This means homes are sitting longer on the market, indicating a slower, more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to Memphis, this could make it easier to find and purchase a home, as the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool. However, it may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an attractive combination of strong wage growth and affordability, which can be beneficial for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which poses a significant challenge for hiring and workforce expansion, making it crucial for businesses to plan strategically for their labor needs.

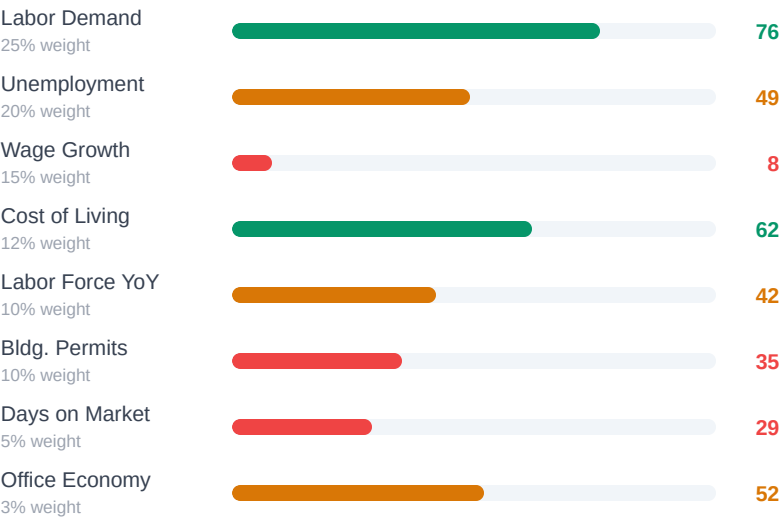
Birmingham

Birmingham

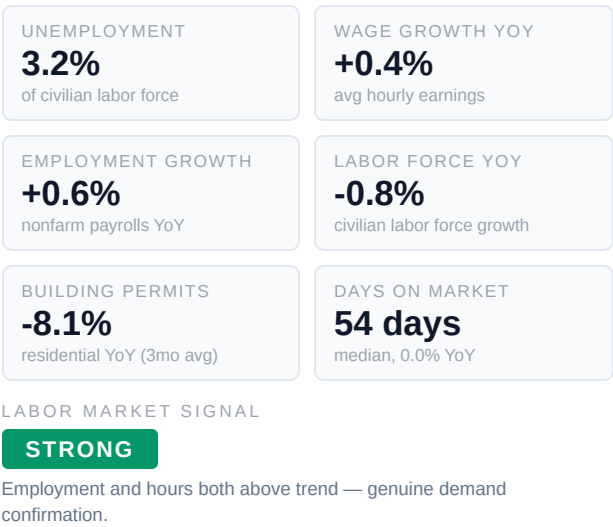
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.2th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 48.2th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and near-median unemployment rate. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.63, driven by a +0.63% employment growth rate and +0.445% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the cost of living, with a PSF of \$160/sqft and a ratio of 4.88 to hourly earnings of \$32.80, ranks in the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively affordable environment.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.63% and weekly hours deviation of +0.445% from its own trend indicate genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a period of labor market growth, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.63, ranking in the 76th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham stands at 3.20%, ranking in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, this also means that wage pressure is not excessively high.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.37%, Birmingham's wage growth is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 8th percentile. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weaker bargaining power for workers and potentially less purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$160/sqft and a ratio of 4.88 to hourly earnings of \$32.80, is relatively affordable, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to balance labor costs and quality of life.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -0.77% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, which could lead to tighter labor market conditions over time.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -8.10%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the future affordability and workforce accommodation in Birmingham may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

Homes in Birmingham are currently sitting on the market for a median of 54 days, with no year-over-year change. This stable market condition means that relocating workers may face a moderately competitive environment, neither extremely fast-paced nor overly slow.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share, ranking in the 52nd percentile, indicates a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles, but may not be the best fit for those requiring a highly specialized or dense knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a relatively affordable cost of living and above-average labor demand, making it an attractive location for certain businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could lead to future hiring challenges and tighter labor market conditions, potentially offsetting the city's current advantages.

St. Louis

St. Louis

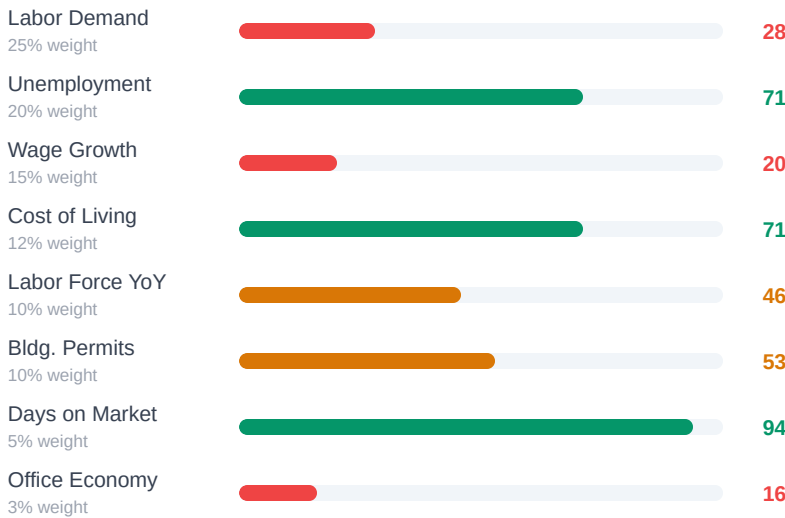
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.9th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+1.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
44 days
median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.9th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.50 ranking at the 28th percentile, and its above-average unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks at the 71st percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a relatively tight labor market but sluggish job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is -0.27% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.423% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.50 confirms this, ranking below average at the 28th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.60%, ranking above average at the 71st percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it's still possible to find qualified workers without excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is +1.53%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This suggests stagnant wage growth, which implies a flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost increases, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living score ranking above average at the 71st percentile, with a PSF of \$164/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.16/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.41. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which is a talent attraction advantage. Businesses can attract workers without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of -0.72% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This indicates a contracting labor pool, which poses a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers, and the shrinking labor pool may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +1.84% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 53rd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation. As the city's housing stock grows, it may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in St. Louis is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%, ranking at the top tier of the 94th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a hot and competitive environment.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in St. Louis is ranked at the bottom tier of the 16th percentile, with a composite score of 1.28. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a tight labor market, but its sluggish job growth and stagnant wage growth pose challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's contracting labor pool, which may limit its ability to support rapid business growth and require businesses to invest in talent development and attraction strategies.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

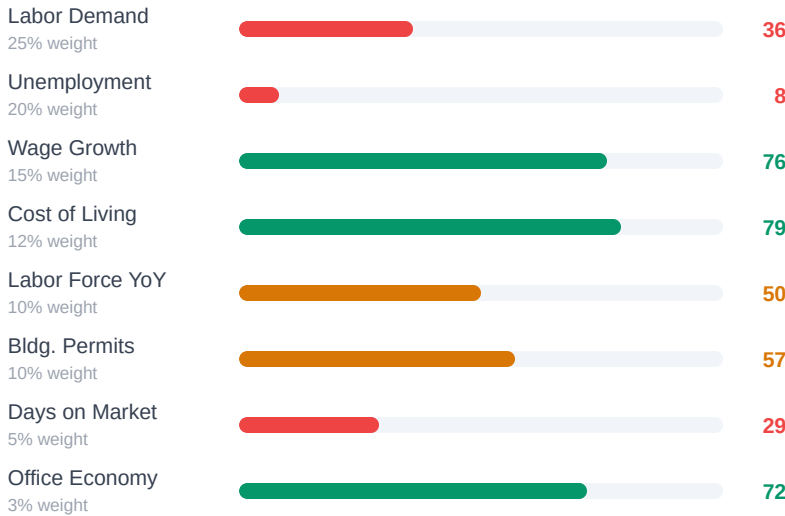
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.8th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.3%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+3.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

68 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.78 ranking it in the 36th percentile, and its high wage growth rate of 5.90% year-over-year, ranking it in the 76th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -0.03% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.480%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.78 is below average, ranking in the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.50%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with significant slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire due to intense competition for available workers. The practical implication is that businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.90%, ranking it in the 76th percentile as above average. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increased worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living score ranking it in the 79th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than most peer cities. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$238/sqft vs \$37.05/hr, with a ratio of 6.42, and PSF is falling by -4.4% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction magnet, allowing businesses to hire without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of -0.30% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a slightly contracting labor pool, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses should consider the potential challenges in finding and retaining workers in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +3.02%, ranking it near the median at the 57th percentile. This moderate increase in permits suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. However, the pace of expansion is not rapid, and businesses should monitor the situation to ensure it meets their needs.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking it in the 29th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses should consider the potential impact on worker relocation and retention in this competitive market.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it in the 72nd percentile. This makes it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent acquisition and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and potential challenges in finding and retaining workers, which may require strategic hiring and retention strategies to overcome.

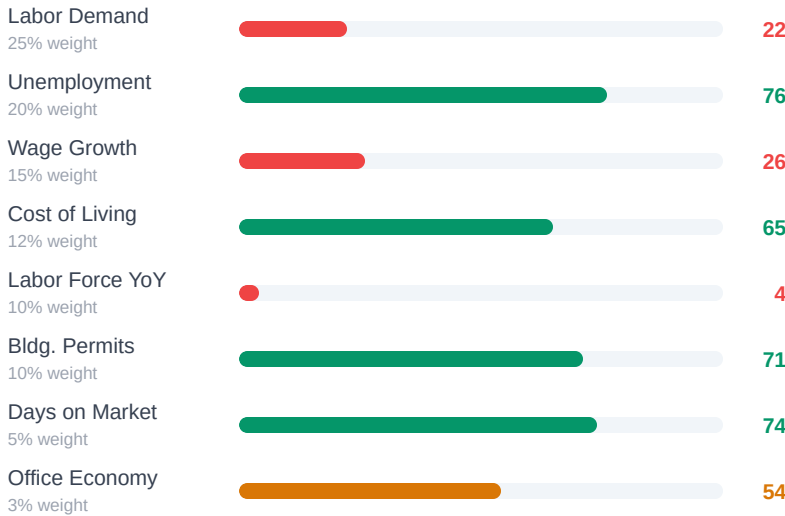
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

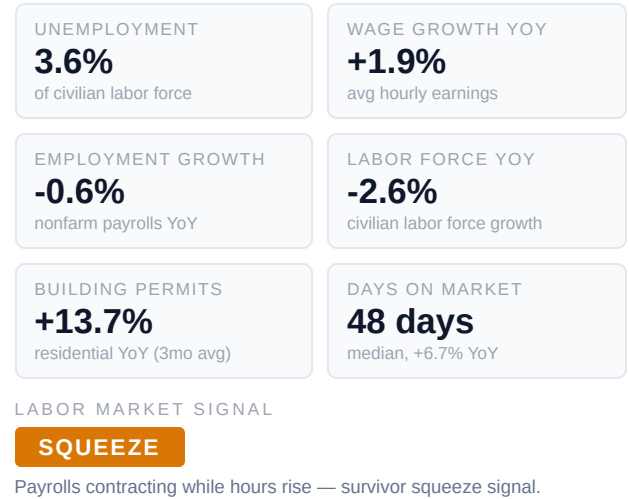
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.1th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.35 ranking it at the 22nd percentile, and its above-average unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks it at the 76th percentile. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some signs of weakness in job growth and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.57% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.147%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing significantly despite some job losses. This suggests that the city's labor market is not experiencing strong growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.60%, which is relatively low and ranks the city at the 76th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that recruiting and retaining talent may be more challenging and expensive.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +1.87%, which is below average and ranks the city at the 26th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not rapidly, and worker purchasing power is growing, but not strongly. This may impact businesses' decisions on hiring and compensation packages.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 65th percentile, with a PSF of \$286/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.72. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a PSF that is decreasing by -3.7% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.58% year-over-year, which ranks the city at the 4th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face structural headwinds in finding and recruiting talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing by +13.68% year-over-year, which ranks the city at the 71st percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city's affordability and workforce accommodation may improve in the future, as more housing units become available.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is currently 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.7%, which ranks the city at the 74th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share that ranks it at the 54th percentile, with a composite score of 2.80. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less ideal for industries with limited office-based roles.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slow housing market, which can be attractive for talent relocation. However, the city's below-average labor demand and shrinking labor force supply pose significant risks and constraints for businesses looking to hire and grow in this market, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location.

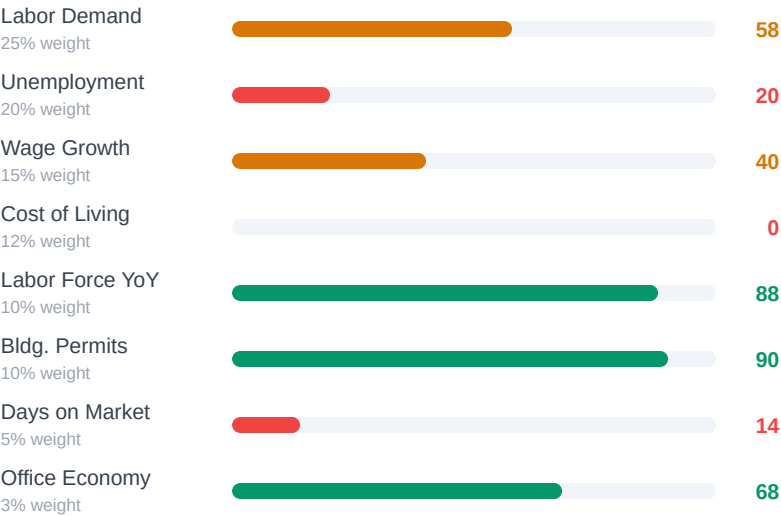
Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.1th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor force growth rate of 1.69% YoY and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living ratio of 10.13, ranking it at the 0th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce but significant challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to high costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is 0.60% YoY, while weekly hours are deviating -0.326% from the city's own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.81, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs but with hours worked slightly below trend, indicating some level of genuine demand but not as strong as in other metros. The labor market is not experiencing a significant contraction or survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking at the 20th percentile, indicating a below-average performance and suggesting that the labor market has some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may find it somewhat easier to staff their operations compared to tighter labor markets, but they may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Providence-Warwick is at a rate of 3.52% YoY, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising but not at an alarming pace, while workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the growth is not strong enough to significantly drive up labor costs or bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living ratio of 10.13, with PSF at \$366/sqft and hourly earnings at \$36.14/hr, ranking at the 0th percentile, making it one of the least affordable cities relative to its peers. This low affordability score, despite being inverted, means that the city is actually very expensive, requiring businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, which can be a significant disadvantage in talent attraction and retention.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of 1.69% YoY, ranking at the 88th percentile, indicating a top-tier performance in labor force expansion. This means that the supply of potential workers is increasing, which can be beneficial for

businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of candidates.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by 41.33% YoY, ranking at the 90th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which could improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 32 days, with a YoY increase of 3.2%, ranking at the 14th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market that is becoming slightly slower, which could be seen as a normalization of the housing market. For relocating workers, this means that the market is still competitive, but there might be a bit more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office and professional worker share of 3.14, ranking at the 68th percentile, indicating an above-average depth of professional talent. This makes the city more suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that rely on a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, but less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The bottom line for businesses considering Providence-Warwick is that while the city offers a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, its extremely high cost of living poses a significant risk for talent attraction and retention, requiring substantial wage premiums to compete. This single biggest constraint could outweigh the city's other advantages, making it crucial for decision-makers to carefully weigh these factors in their location decision.

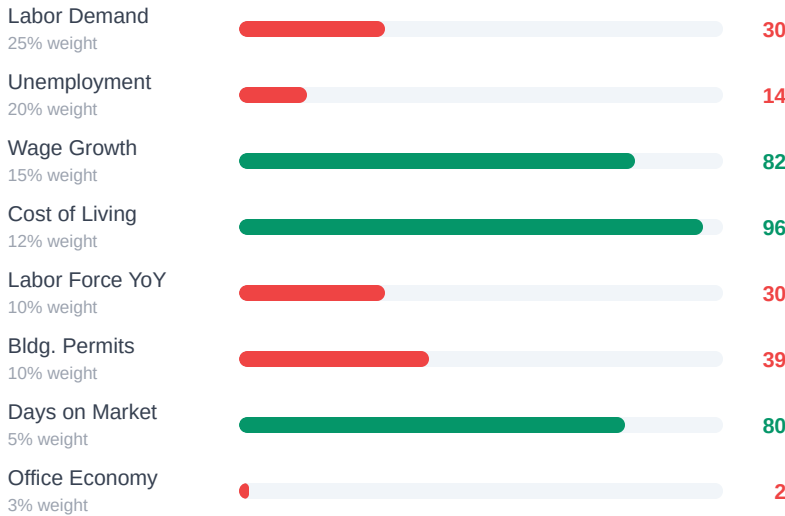
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.1th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 6.51% year-over-year and its extremely affordable cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.05, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. These two metrics suggest a city with strong labor costs and an attractive environment for workers.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.54% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is +0.000%, indicating a labor demand composite score of 3.54, which ranks below average at the 30th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The city's payrolls are contracting, and hours are not deviating significantly from trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.20%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing significant wage pressure. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

Oklahoma City's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.51%, ranking it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in increasing labor costs, but also consider the benefits of a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City is an extremely affordable city, with a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, driven by a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.05, where the PSF is \$172/sqft and declining by 0.6% year-over-year, and earnings are \$34.08/hr. This means that the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is contracting at a rate of -1.07% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is not expanding to meet demand. Businesses should plan accordingly and consider strategies to attract workers from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Oklahoma City is declining by 6.33% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals a potential future affordability and workforce accommodation challenge, as the supply of housing is not expanding to meet demand. Businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of this trend on their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.3%, ranking it in the above-average tier at the 80th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend also suggests a potential normalization of the market, rather than a sign of demand erosion.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share is relatively low, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This suggests a shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, the city may be more attractive for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

Oklahoma City offers businesses an attractive combination of high wage growth and extremely affordable cost of living, making it an excellent location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's contracting labor force and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.4th percentile
Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		20
25% weight		
Unemployment		49
20% weight		
Wage Growth		56
15% weight		
Cost of Living		67
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		56
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		24
10% weight		
Days on Market		88
5% weight		
Office Economy		26
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -11.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 36 days median, +9.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.28, and its relatively high cost of living, with a ratio of \$219/sqft to \$36.68/hr, ranking it 67th percentile in affordability. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's economic landscape, with employment growth at -0.73% and weekly hours deviation at -0.398%.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.73%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.398% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in both job creation and working hours. As a result, businesses may face a less competitive environment for talent, but also less pressure to increase wages.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 3.90%, ranking it near the median at the 49th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the availability of labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +4.24%, ranking it near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace. Additionally, workers in the area are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to local economic activity.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living ratio of \$219/sqft to \$36.68/hr, with the price per square foot decreasing by -1.4% year-over-year, ranking it 67th percentile in affordability. This means that the city is more affordable than many of its peers, which can be a significant advantage for talent attraction without requiring wage premiums. Businesses can leverage this affordability to attract and retain workers without incurring excessive labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of -0.22% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This contraction implies that the hiring capacity for businesses may be limited, posing a structural headwind for companies

looking to expand their workforce in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has decreased by -11.88% year-over-year, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially leading to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.1%, ranking it at the 88th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to the city may find it more accessible to purchase or rent a home, as properties are staying on the market longer. However, this also indicates a less competitive housing market, which may be a concern for businesses relying on a dynamic and growing population.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is below average, ranking at the 26th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, making it less suited for businesses that rely heavily on these sectors. However, the city may be more attractive to industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate pace of wage growth, but it is constrained by below-average labor demand and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited hiring capacity due to the contracting labor pool, which may pose a significant challenge for companies looking to expand their operations in the area.

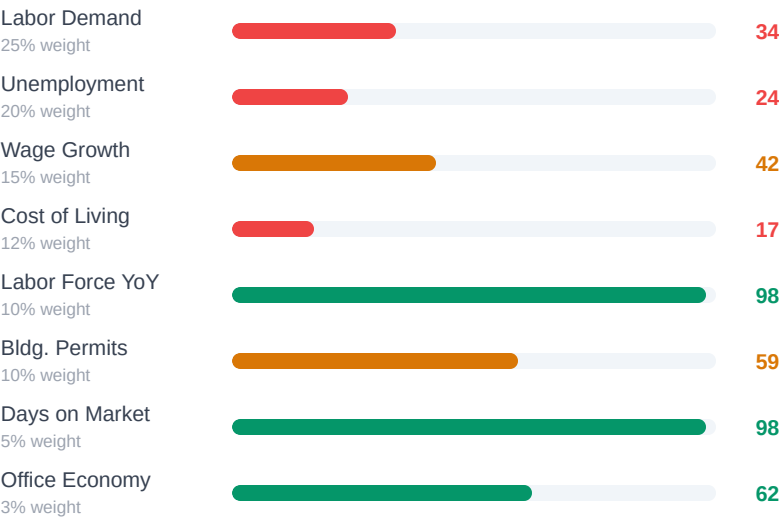
Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

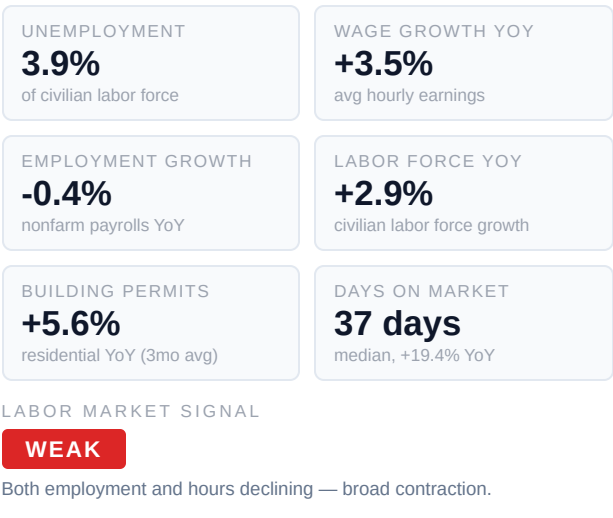
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.2th percentile
Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor force growth and office economy, with a labor force growth rate of 2.87% YoY and an office/professional worker share ranking in the 62nd percentile. The combination of a strong labor force expansion and a deep professional talent pool makes this city an attractive location for businesses seeking skilled workers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.44% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.650% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.68, which ranks in the 34th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a slowdown in job growth and a decrease in working hours. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for workers, but also a less dynamic labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking in the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring workers, as the pool of available candidates is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power, which could lead to higher labor costs for businesses.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.53%, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a moderate pace, and workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. However, the moderate wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the cost of living in the city, which could impact the attractiveness of the location for workers.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score ranking in the 17th percentile, with a PSF of \$486/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$45.89/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.59. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may offset the benefits of the city's strong labor force growth and professional talent pool.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% YoY, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating a rapid expansion of the workforce. This means that businesses have access to a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to hire and staff their operations. The strong labor force growth also suggests that the city is likely to have a diverse and dynamic labor market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is increasing by 5.64% YoY, ranking in the 59th percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of the housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing a gradual increase in housing availability, which could help to improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the moderate pace of growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the demand for housing, which could lead to ongoing affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 19.4%, ranking in the 98th percentile. This indicates that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the city. The slower market may give workers more time to find a home, reducing the stress and competition associated with a hot market.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has an office/professional worker share ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool of professional and office workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of skilled workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor force growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking skilled workers. However, the city's high cost of living and relatively tight labor market may pose challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain talent, and the moderate wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the cost of living, making it the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in.

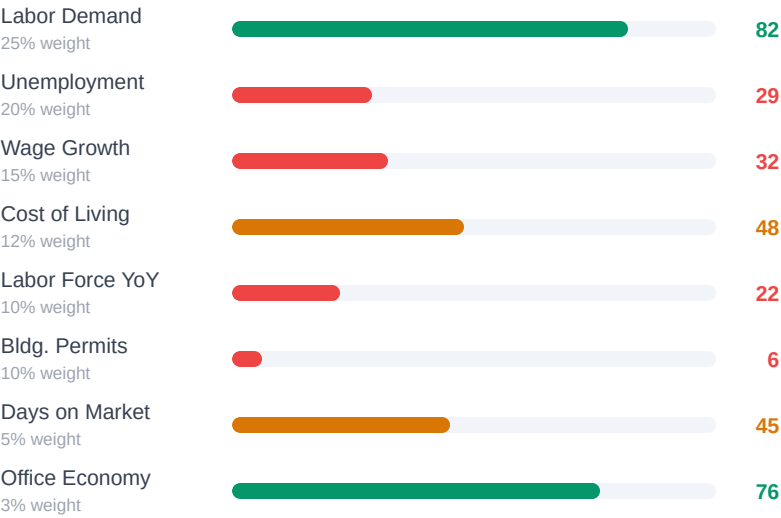
Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

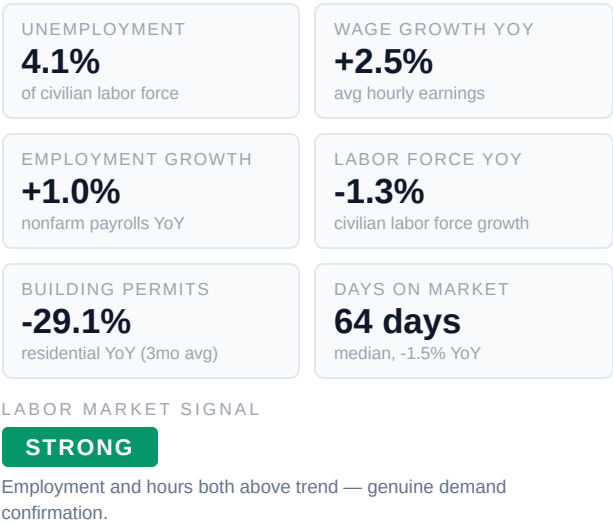
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.1th percentile
Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 82nd percentile ranking, and its below-average unemployment rate of 4.10%, which ranks at the 29th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.84, driven by a +0.96% employment growth rate and +0.193% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.96% and weekly hours deviation of +0.193% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.84 reinforces this assessment, ranking at the 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% is below the national average, ranking at the 29th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.55% is moderate, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. Workers in the area can expect to see some increase in their purchasing power, but it may not be enough to keep pace with cost of living increases.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.22, based on \$269/sqft and \$37.26/hr, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks at the 48th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.8% YoY also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.31% year-over-year, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding their workforce. The shrinking labor pool may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -29.08%, ranking at the 6th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city may be facing a future affordability crisis, which could impact its ability to attract and retain workers. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of skilled workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 64 days, with a year-over-year decline of -1.5%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively competitive, but not extremely so. Workers relocating to the city may still find it accessible, but the market is not as slow as it could be.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.30, ranking at the 76th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, and consulting businesses. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers, but it may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the declining labor force supply and sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. Despite these challenges, the city's relatively affordable cost of living and deep professional talent pool make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, decision-makers should carefully consider the potential risks and constraints when evaluating this city as a potential location.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

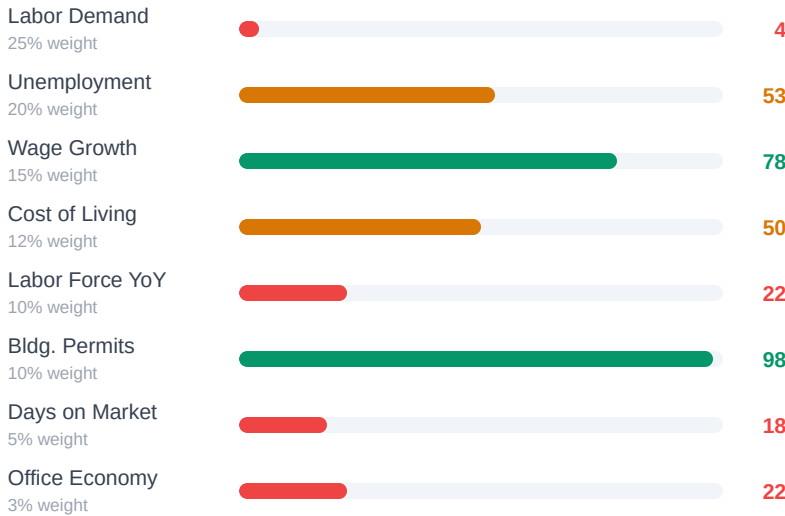
C+

POOR

42.9th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.3%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+163.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days
median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 1.56, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.14% in hourly earnings. The combination of a -0.96% employment growth rate and +1.397% weekly hours deviation signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.96% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 1.397% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where the remaining workforce is taking on more hours to compensate for the loss of jobs. The labor demand composite score of 1.56 ranks in the bottom tier, at the 4th percentile, indicating weak labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.70%, ranking near the median at the 53rd percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in this area, the moderate unemployment rate means that hiring may not be overly competitive, but it also may not be extremely easy to find qualified candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 6.14%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This strong wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is near the median, with a percentile rank of 50th, and a price-to-salary ratio of 6.35, based on \$224/sqft and \$35.27/hr. The fact that the PSF is rising 2.3% year-over-year relative to wages means that the city is not becoming more affordable. This neutral cost of living means that businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to affordability, and may need to offer wage premiums to compete.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -1.31% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find qualified candidates. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area is increasing by 163.12% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and growing pool of potential employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, means that the market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges finding housing. Businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or flexible work arrangements to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in this metro area is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. As a result, this city may be better suited for businesses in industrial or logistics sectors, rather than those requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a rapidly expanding housing supply, but it also poses significant challenges due to its low labor demand and shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the survivor squeeze and the resulting competition for a limited pool of qualified candidates, which may drive up labor costs and require significant investment in training and development programs.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

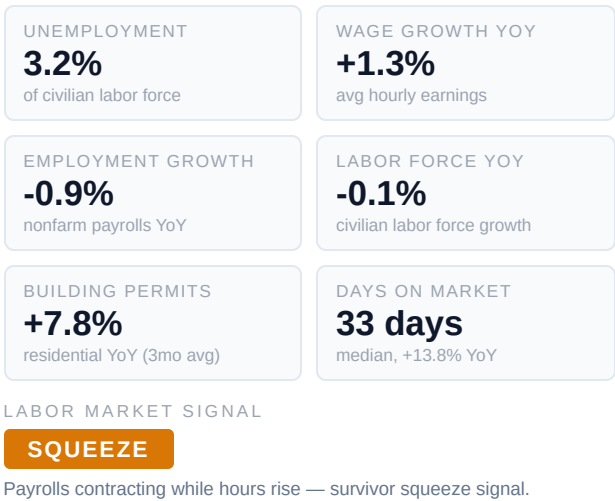
42.8th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.20% ranking it in the top tier. The labor demand and unemployment metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.86% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.000% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.10, which is in the bottom tier. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate. The lack of genuine demand expansion may pose challenges for businesses relying on a growing workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.20%, ranking it in the top tier, which means the market is tight with minimal slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face difficulties in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.33%, which is in the bottom tier, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth may keep labor costs flat for employers, but it also means that workers may have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not need to worry about rapidly rising labor costs, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score ranking it in the 21st percentile, with a PSF of \$230/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$36.46/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.31. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The low affordability score may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, which is above average, but still indicates a contracting labor pool. This contraction may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate the limited labor supply.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +7.85% year-over-year, which is above average. This expansion in housing supply may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. The rising permits suggest that developers are confident in the city's prospects, which may lead to a more favorable business environment.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.8%, ranking it in the top tier. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower and more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it more accessible to find housing, but it also suggests that the city's housing market may not be as competitive as others.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is relatively low, ranking it in the 16th percentile. This indicates that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics.

In conclusion, Milwaukee-Waukesha offers a unique combination of a tight labor market and relatively expensive cost of living, which may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the low labor demand and contracting labor pool, which may limit the city's potential for growth and development.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

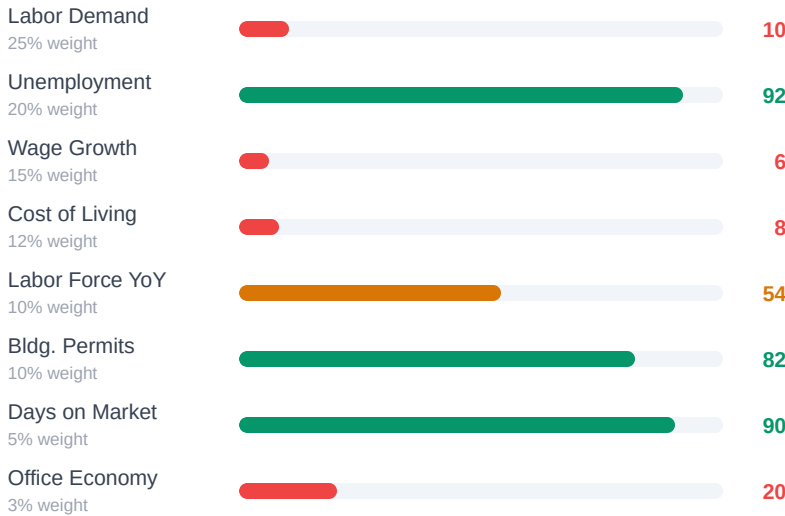
C+

POOR

41.4th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.2%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+19.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.00% ranking it in the top tier. The combination of these two metrics, particularly the low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, signals a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.06% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.398%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as the hours worked are slightly above trend despite job losses. This scenario may indicate a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.00%, ranking it in the top tier with a percentile score of 92. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there is less slack in the market, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.36%, ranking it in the bottom tier with a percentile score of 6. This stagnant wage growth signals that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. The implication for employer labor costs is that they can expect a relatively flat cost environment, but workers may have weak bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score ranking it in the bottom tier with a percentile score of 8, with a PSF of \$167/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.09. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The city's low affordability score may put it at a disadvantage in competing for businesses and workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is growing at a rate of -0.25% year-over-year, ranking it near the median with a percentile score of 54. This contraction in labor force supply means that the hiring capacity for businesses may be limited, and they may need to invest in training and development to attract and retain workers. The implication for hiring is that businesses may face structural headwinds in finding qualified workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is increasing by +19.68% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier with a percentile score of 82. This expansion in housing supply signals that developer confidence is strong, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.8%, ranking it in the top tier with a percentile score of 90. This means that the market is relatively slow, and workers relocating to the city may have an easier time finding a home. The rising days on market indicates a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is below average, ranking it in the 20th percentile. This means that the city's talent pool is not as deep as other metros, and it may be less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. The city's office economy is more geared towards industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively stable and slow-growing economy, with a tight labor market and stagnant wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's low labor demand and relatively expensive cost of living, which may make it challenging to attract and retain talent without offering competitive salaries and benefits.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C+

POOR

40.4th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		42
25% weight		
Unemployment		39
20% weight		
Wage Growth		74
15% weight		
Cost of Living		42
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		6
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		33
10% weight		
Days on Market		43
5% weight		
Office Economy		0
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings
4.6%	+5.7%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth
-0.1%	-2.3%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET median, +1.7% YoY
-9.6%	59 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL	
WEAK	
Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is near median, and its wage growth, which is above average at 5.74% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics, along with a below-average unemployment rate of 4.60%, suggests a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is -0.12% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.210% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 4.60%, which is below average and corresponds to a percentile rank of 39th. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire in this city. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.74%, which is above average and ranks in the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means good news for worker purchasing power. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score that ranks near median, with a PSF of \$335/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.50/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.44. The PSF is falling by -2.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of the city's affordability. With a percentile rank of 42nd, the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, making it a moderately attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -2.31% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier and corresponds to a percentile rank of 6th. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and attract new talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is decreasing by -9.55% year-over-year, which is below average and ranks in the 33rd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%. This indicates a moderately competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are sitting on the market for a relatively average amount of time. However, the rising trend may signal a normalization of the market, making it slightly more accessible for workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share that ranks in the bottom tier and corresponds to a percentile rank of 0th. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a mixed economic environment with above-average wage growth, but also faces challenges such as a contracting labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the declining labor force supply, which may limit their ability to find and attract new talent, making it essential to factor this into their location decision.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

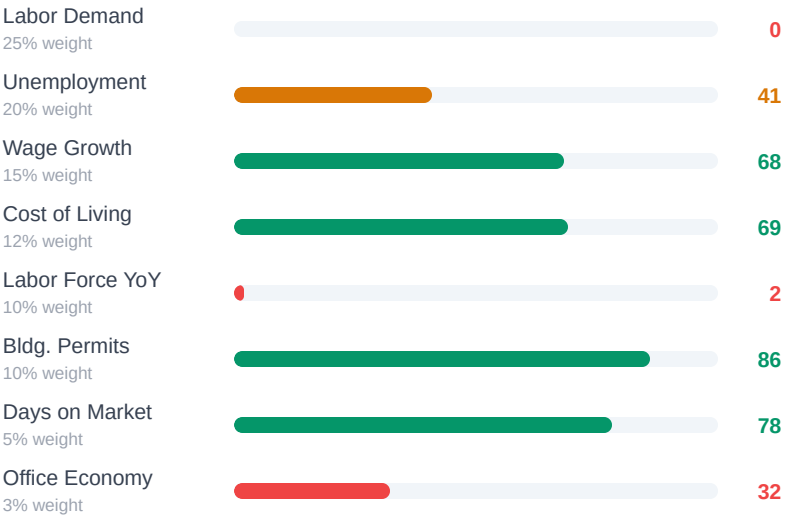
C+

POOR

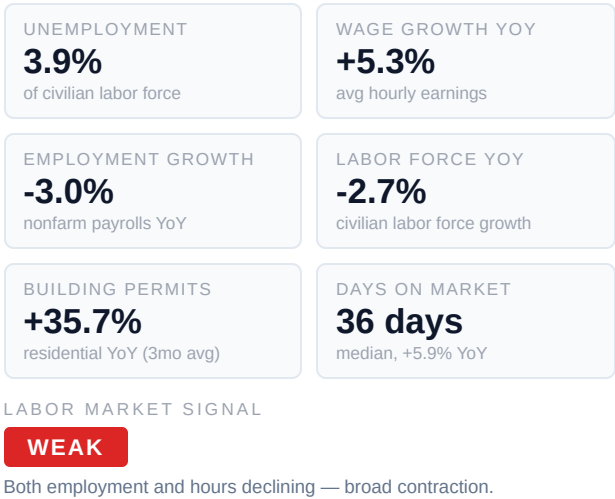
40.2th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a -2.95% employment growth rate and a -0.771% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, as well as its above-average wage growth of +5.31% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.95%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.771% from the city's own 12-month trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 1.50. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This scenario suggests that businesses may face a challenging hiring environment due to a lack of available workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 41st percentile. This rate indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still suggests that businesses may face some competition for top talent, potentially driving up wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is +5.31%, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals that labor costs for employers are rising, which may be a challenge for businesses looking to control expenses. On the other hand, workers in the area will benefit from increased purchasing power, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score ranking it above average at the 69th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$308/sqft to \$44.92/hr, or 6.86. The fact that the PSF is falling -2.2% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor for businesses, as workers may be willing to accept lower wages due to the lower cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -2.72% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply indicates that the city's workforce is shrinking, which can create structural headwinds

for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by +35.66% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This rapid growth in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This trend is a positive indicator for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area, as it suggests that the city is investing in its infrastructure and housing stock.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.9%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This slower pace of home sales can make the city's housing market more accessible to relocating workers, as they may have more time to find and purchase a home. However, this trend may also indicate a normalization of the housing market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is below average, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting industries. However, the city may still be attractive to businesses in other sectors, such as logistics or manufacturing, that require a different type of workforce.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average wage growth and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent acquisition and retention. However, the city's weak labor demand and contracting labor force supply pose significant risks and constraints for businesses looking to expand or relocate in the area, and decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C

VERY POOR

36.8th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		24
Unemployment 20% weight		29
Wage Growth 15% weight		14
Cost of Living 12% weight		90
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		62
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		22
Days on Market 5% weight		41
Office Economy 3% weight		58

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.1%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +1.2%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.1%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -12.0%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -1.6% YoY 61 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 3.36, combining a +0.40% employment growth rate and a -2.201% weekly hours deviation from trend, suggests a weak labor market. Additionally, the wage growth rate of +1.25% year-over-year is a key metric defining the city's economic character, indicating slow labor cost increases.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.40% and weekly hours deviation of -2.201% from trend signal a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a mild contraction. This combination indicates that while some jobs are being added, the hours worked are below the city's own trend, suggesting a lack of robust labor demand. This scenario may lead to a surplus of workers, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially limiting wage growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. This rate suggests that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, as there is a pool of available labor. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate compared to other metros.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.25% is stagnant, indicating slow labor cost increases for employers. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that workers may not have strong bargaining power, potentially limiting their purchasing power and overall economic activity. For businesses, this means a relatively flat labor cost environment, which can be beneficial for controlling expenses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$32.19/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of -5.0% in PSF, San Antonio-New Braunfels ranks in the top tier (90th percentile) for affordability. This high affordability score means that the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively low compared to other metros.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.11% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing, potentially making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -12.00%, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand, potentially driving up costs and limiting the city's attractiveness to relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 61 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.6%. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decrease in days on market indicates a hot market, which can be challenging for workers trying to relocate to the area.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 2.86, ranking near the median (58th percentile), San Antonio-New Braunfels has a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses requiring professional and office workers. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy, but may not be ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or dominant knowledge-economy talent pool.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a flat labor cost environment, but its slow wage growth and contracting labor force pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the limited labor pool and tightening housing supply, which may outweigh the benefits of the city's affordability and moderate labor costs.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

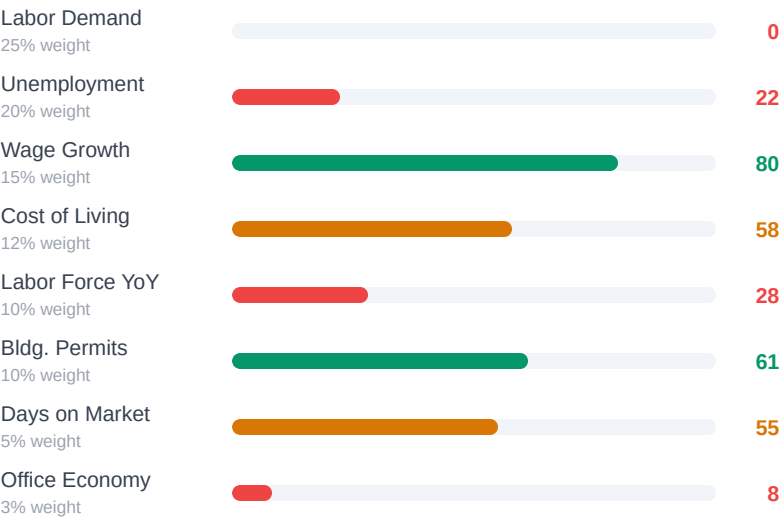
C

VERY POOR

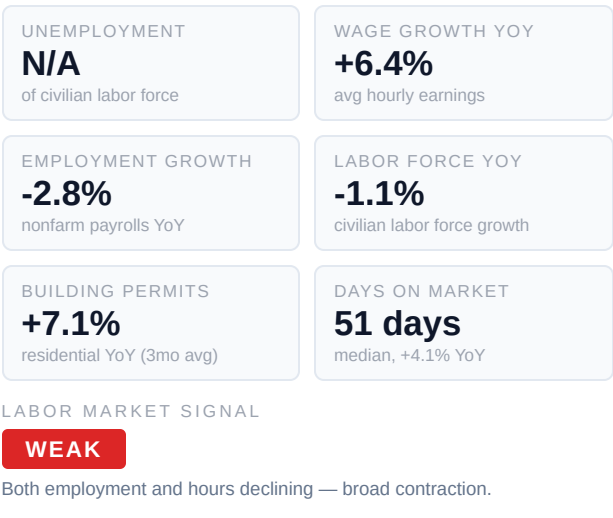
35.4th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and strong wage growth, at -2.81% employment growth and +6.37% wage growth, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining employment growth and weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in the job market. This is further emphasized by the bottom-tier percentile ranks in labor demand metrics.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -2.81% and weekly hours deviation of -0.489% indicate a contraction in labor demand, signaling a lack of genuine demand expansion in the job market. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked, which can lead to a surplus of labor. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 reinforces this notion, ranking at the 0th percentile.

Unemployment

Although the exact unemployment rate is not available, the city's unemployment rate percentile rank of 22nd suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand. With an unemployment rate that is not exceptionally low, businesses may face less competition for talent, but may also encounter a less vibrant local economy.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.37% indicates fast-rising wages, ranking at the 80th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies increasing labor costs for employers, but also stronger worker purchasing power. As wages rise, businesses may need to adjust their budgets to accommodate higher labor costs, while workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 58th, the city is near the median in terms of affordability, with a PSF of \$309/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$41.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.37. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% YoY suggests some improvement in affordability. This near-median affordability ranking means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to cost of living alone, but it also does not require substantial wage premiums to compensate for high costs.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -1.14%, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the available workforce is shrinking. Businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting

talent in a market with a declining labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +7.12%, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which can lead to better affordability and workforce accommodation. As housing supply expands, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.1%. This rising days on market indicates a slowing market, making it slightly more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the near-median percentile rank of 55th suggests that the market is not exceptionally slow or fast, providing a relatively balanced environment for homebuyers.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share percentile rank of 8th, the city has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses relying heavily on tech, finance, or consulting talent, but may be more accommodating to industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The city's economic character is more aligned with traditional industries rather than knowledge-economy sectors.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a unique combination of strong wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, but its weak labor demand and contracting labor force pose significant risks for businesses. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor pool and declining job market, which may hinder hiring and expansion efforts.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

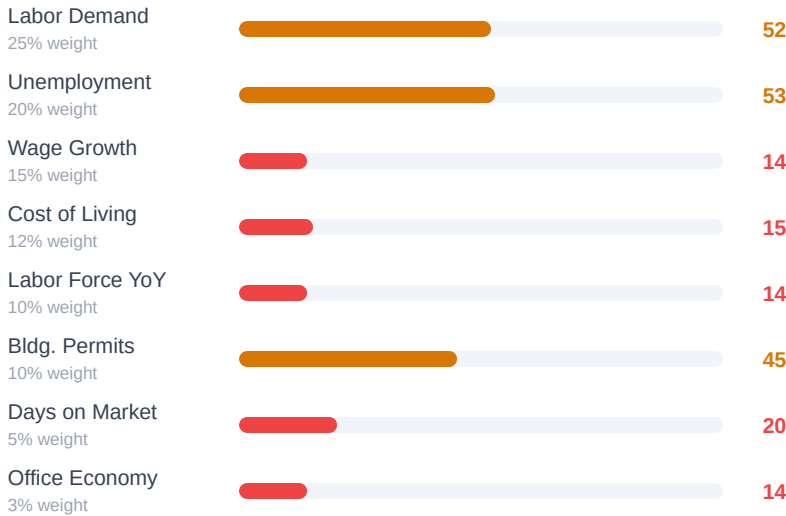
C

VERY POOR

34.8th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.5%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-1.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

43 days

median, -2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.64 and an unemployment rate of 4.20%. The city's current economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth, at +1.25% year-over-year, and its declining labor force growth, at -1.52% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and retain top talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.456% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion of labor demand, but with some signs of strain, as hours are not increasing as quickly as employment. This suggests that while there is some genuine demand expansion, it may not be as robust as in other cities.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.20%, which is near the median for US metros. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor extremely slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find qualified candidates, it also won't be unusually easy, and wages may not be under significant upward or downward pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.25%, which is in the bottom tier of US metros, ranking 14th percentile. This slow wage growth signals a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier, 15th percentile, with a PSF-to-earnings ratio of \$343/sqft to \$38.27/hr, or 8.96. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is not falling year-over-year, but rather stable, suggests that affordability is not improving, and businesses may need to factor in higher costs of living for their employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is shrinking at a rate of -1.52% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier of US metros, ranking 14th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is declining. This could make it more challenging for businesses to find qualified candidates, and may require them to offer more competitive wages or benefits to attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is declining at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year, which is near the median for US metros. This suggests that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as in other cities, which could lead to tighter housing markets and reduced affordability in the future. This may impact the ability of businesses to attract and retain workers, particularly if they are relocating from other areas.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is currently 43 days, with a year-over-year decline of -2.3%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the fact that days on market are declining suggests that the market is still relatively hot, and businesses may need to factor in the potential for rapid price appreciation and reduced affordability.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier, 14th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in these sectors, and may be more suited to businesses in industries such as logistics or manufacturing. However, businesses in tech, finance, or consulting may find it more challenging to attract and retain top talent in this city.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively balanced labor market and a flat cost environment, but also poses significant challenges in terms of stagnant wage growth, declining labor force supply, and relatively high costs of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for reduced affordability and competitiveness in attracting and retaining top talent, particularly in professional and office sectors.

Richmond

Richmond

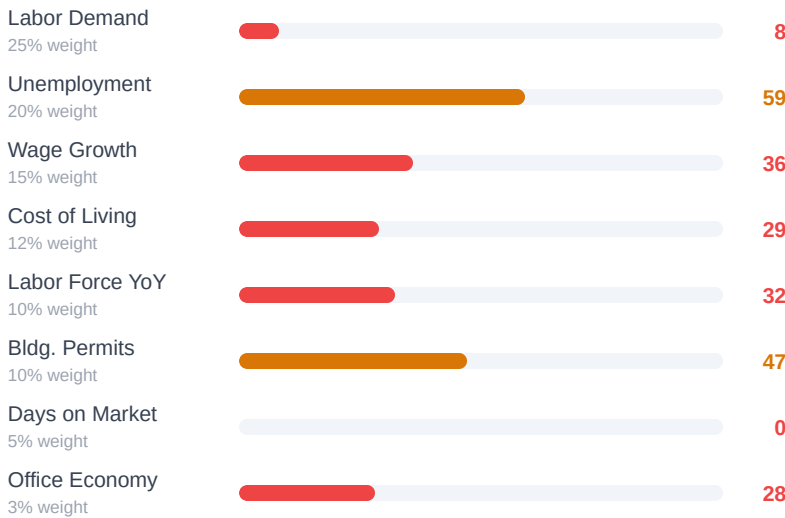
C-

CRITICAL

31.5th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.9%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-0.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days
median, -13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 31.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 2.27, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its low cost of living affordability score, ranking it below average at the 29th percentile with a PSF to earnings ratio of 6.36. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.87% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.807%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as hours are being worked above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers to fill new positions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.50%, ranking it near the median at the 59th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +3.00%, ranking it below average at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other metros. This also means that workers in Richmond have modestly increasing purchasing power, which can support local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking it below average at the 29th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 6.36, based on \$229/sqft and \$36.00/hr. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which can make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by +1.3% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.98% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 32nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses looking to expand in Richmond may face challenges in finding the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Richmond is decreasing by -0.85% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 47th percentile. This slowdown in housing supply expansion suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the demand for housing may outstrip the available supply.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Richmond is currently 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -13.9%. This fast-paced market, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive and potentially challenging for relocating workers to find housing. This can be a deterrent for businesses looking to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share ranks it below average at the 28th percentile, with a composite score of 1.68. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Richmond metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost operating environment, but its weak labor demand, shrinking labor force, and competitive housing market pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited talent pool and the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining skilled workers, which can hinder business growth and expansion plans.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C-

CRITICAL

30.7th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		18
25% weight		
Unemployment		2
20% weight		
Wage Growth		22
15% weight		
Cost of Living		40
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		94
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		29
10% weight		
Days on Market		84
5% weight		
Office Economy		44
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 5.5%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +1.7%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.8%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +2.2%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -11.4%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +8.6% YoY 38 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high labor force growth rate, which is in the top tier at 94th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 3.25 and labor force growth rate of +2.21% YoY are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.75% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.730% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may not face strong competition for workers, but it also implies a slower economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.50%, ranking it in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the low unemployment rate also suggests that local consumer demand may be weaker due to a larger proportion of the labor force being unemployed.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.73%, ranking it below average at 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit gradually. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still attracting and retaining workers.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking it below average at 40th percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$36.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.10. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is not falling YoY further reinforces the notion that the city's affordability is not improving.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.21% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, making it easier for businesses to find and recruit workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -11.39% YoY, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially leading to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is currently 38 days, with a YoY increase of +8.6%. This suggests a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising DOM indicates a healthy normalization of the housing market, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn ranks near the median at 44th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but it may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech or finance talent.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively slow housing market, making it easier to attract and retain workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and tightening housing supply, which could lead to increased competition for workers and higher labor costs in the long run.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C-

CRITICAL

29.5th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)

Labor Demand		44
25% weight		
Unemployment		33
20% weight		
Wage Growth		10
15% weight		
Cost of Living		33
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		20
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		26
10% weight		
Days on Market		29
5% weight		
Office Economy		12
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.4% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -11.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 37 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 29.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low wage growth, at +0.54% year-over-year, and its below-average labor force growth, at -1.38% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.495% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a modest expansion in job numbers, but with hours worked below trend, indicating some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests genuine demand is not as strong as the employment growth rate alone might indicate.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 3.90%, ranking it at the 33rd percentile, which means the market has some slack but is not overly loose. This rate implies that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may face moderate wage pressure. However, the relatively low unemployment rate compared to other metros suggests that local consumer demand might be supported.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.54%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could impact the attractiveness of the area for businesses looking for a cost-controlled environment but may not support strong local economic growth.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 33rd percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$212/sqft to \$39.59/hr, or 5.35. Although the PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year, the overall affordability is still below average. This means the city is not particularly advantageous for talent attraction without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living, while not extremely high, does not provide a significant edge in competitiveness.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is shrinking at a rate of -1.38% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. This could pose significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area, as finding and retaining talent may become increasingly difficult.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -11.74%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This sharp decline signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could exacerbate existing challenges in attracting and retaining workers, especially if housing costs continue to rise due to limited supply.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 37 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 29th percentile, means homes are selling quickly, which can be competitive and challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable year-over-year direction suggests a degree of normalization in the housing market.

Office Economy

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a professional and office worker share that places it in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, suggesting the city might be more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics. The city's economy is not as strongly aligned with knowledge-economy sectors.

The bottom line for businesses considering Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is that while it offers a moderate cost environment and some slack in the labor market, the significant risks include stagnant wage growth, a shrinking labor force, and tightening housing supply. The single biggest constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the challenge of attracting and retaining talent in a market with limited labor force growth and below-average affordability, which could impact long-term operational viability and expansion plans.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

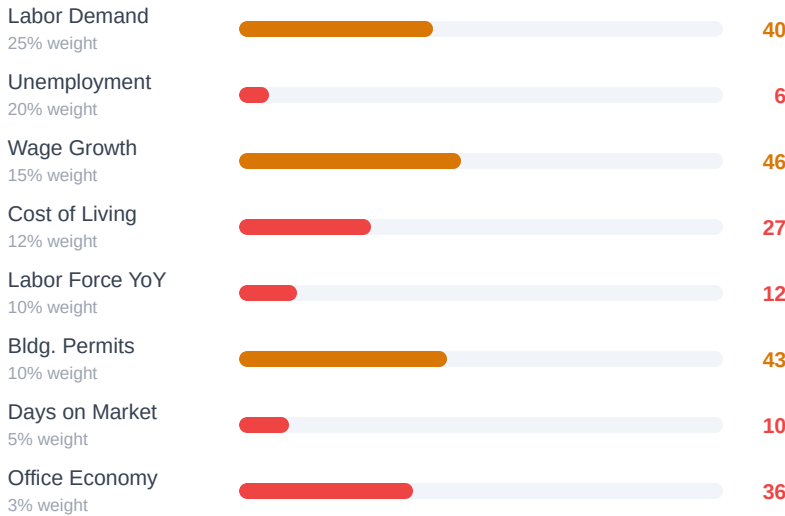
C-

CRITICAL

28.5th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.7%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-1.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

33 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 28.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.90% and its stagnant labor force growth rate of -1.66% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with limited supply of new workers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -0.01% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.300%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.99 ranks near the median at the 40th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, ranking it at the 6th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for workers and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand due to a smaller pool of unemployed individuals.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.59%, ranking it near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in this city are experiencing an increase in their purchasing power, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score ranking it at the 27th percentile, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.81/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.00. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.8% YoY relative to wages makes it even less affordable. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent to this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -1.66% YoY, ranking it at the 12th percentile. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring in this city. Businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract workers from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is decreasing by -1.45% YoY, ranking it near the median at the 43rd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. However, the relatively slow decline in permits may not immediately impact the city's attractiveness to businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 33 days, with a YoY change of +0.0%, ranking it at the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find accommodation. The stable YoY direction suggests that this trend is unlikely to change soon.

Office Economy

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has an office economy score ranking it at the 36th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.10 out of 5. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses requiring a large pool of specialized workers or those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but its low unemployment rate and shrinking labor force supply pose significant challenges for hiring and talent attraction. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain workers, potentially offsetting the benefits of operating in this location.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

D

EMERGENCY

20.7th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-6.2%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-21.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

33 days

median, -8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 20.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its weak labor demand and high cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 3.43, which combines a -0.62% employment growth rate and a -0.775% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in job opportunities. The cost of living, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.85, ranks in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive market.

Labor Demand

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an employment growth rate of -0.62% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.775% from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with both jobs and hours worked declining. The result is a labor market with limited opportunities for growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.40%, ranking in the 35th percentile, which suggests a moderate level of slack in the labor market. While this is not extremely high, it still indicates that the market is not tight, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.67%, ranking in the 34th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit at a moderate pace. This could be seen as a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living percentile rank of 6th, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.85, indicating a relatively expensive market. This low affordability score means that the city is at a disadvantage for talent attraction, as workers may require wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living. The 6.2% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -6.22% year-over-year, ranking in the 0th percentile, which signals a significant structural headwind for hiring. This decline in labor force supply implies that businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers, as the pool of potential employees is shrinking.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has decreased by -21.72% year-over-year, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 33 days, with a -8.3% year-over-year change, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. However, the rapid sale of homes may make it challenging for relocating workers to find suitable housing, as homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has an office economy percentile rank of 10th, with a professional worker share of 0.80, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers a relatively low-cost labor environment, but its high cost of living and contracting labor force supply pose significant risks for businesses considering relocation. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor market growth and shrinking labor pool, which may hinder hiring capacity and talent attraction.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

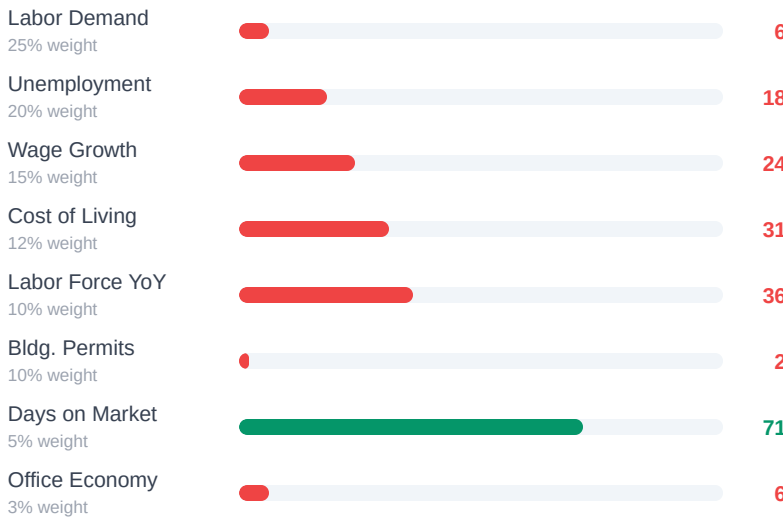
D

EMERGENCY

20.1th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.0%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-31.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

6 Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 20.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.11. The city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with employment growth of -0.85% YoY, and its struggling housing market, with building permits declining by -31.15% YoY. These metrics signal significant challenges for businesses looking to locate or expand in the area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.85% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.999% indicate a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, making it difficult for businesses to find the talent they need. The labor demand composite score of 2.11, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile, further reinforces this concern.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.60% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also means that wage pressure may be lower, giving businesses more flexibility in terms of labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.79% is below average, ranking at 24th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. The moderate wage growth may make it easier for businesses to manage labor costs, but it also means that workers may not have as much disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$179/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.76, ranks below average at 31st percentile, indicating a relatively affordable city. However, the fact that PSF is not falling YoY means that affordability is not improving. The relatively affordable cost of living means that businesses may be able to attract talent without having to offer significant wage premiums, giving them a competitive advantage in terms of labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -0.96%, indicating a contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and potentially driving up labor costs. The negative labor force growth rate, ranking below average at 36th percentile, reinforces the concern that the city's labor market is struggling to expand.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -31.15%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This means that the city's housing market is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. The low ranking at 2nd percentile further emphasizes the concern that the city's housing market is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 40 days, with a YoY increase of +5.3%, indicating a slowing market. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the area. The above-average ranking at 71st percentile suggests that the market is normalizing, but the slow pace of sales may still pose challenges for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 0.50, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This means that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a labor market with some slack, but it also poses significant challenges in terms of labor demand, housing supply, and talent pool depth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the city's struggling labor market, with weak labor demand and a contracting labor pool, which may make it difficult to find and retain talent.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

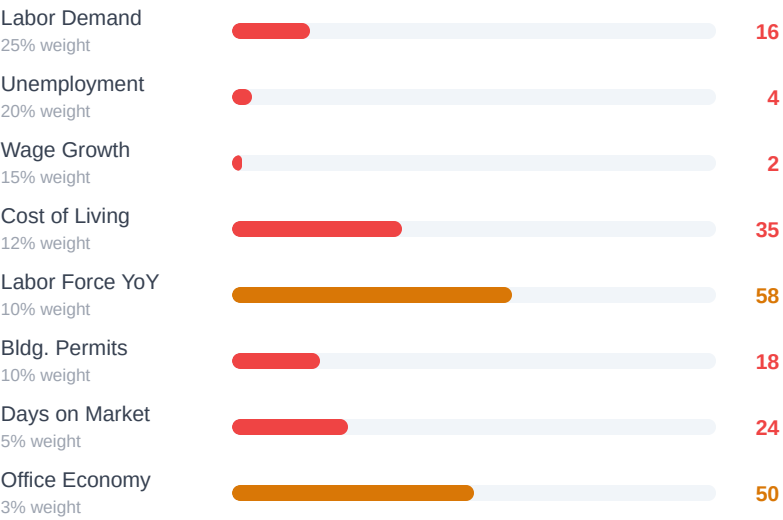
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EMERGENCY

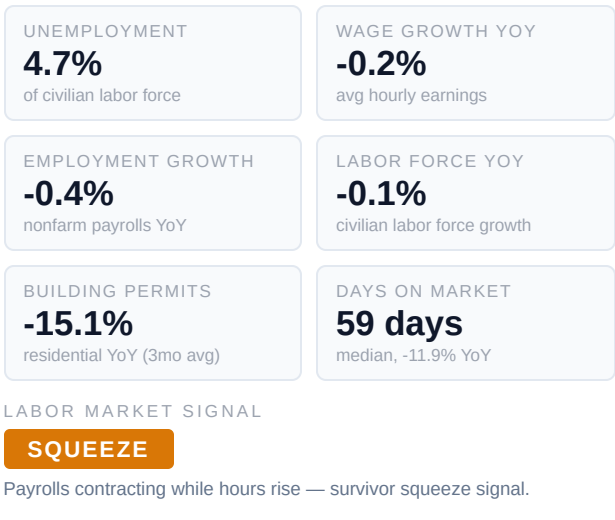
19.7th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of D, ranking 19.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.14, which falls in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.70% and stagnant wage growth of -0.16% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging labor market for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is -0.37% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.645% above the city's own 12-month trend. However, the combination of these metrics signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This indicates a lack of job creation and potential labor market constraints.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.70%, which is in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure is likely to be high. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Jacksonville is stagnant, with a year-over-year change of -0.16%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are flat, but worker purchasing power is weak. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may have limited disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score that ranks at the 35th percentile, with a PSF of \$217/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.7% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of \$36.14/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.00. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is contracting at a rate of -0.15% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This means that the workforce supply is shrinking, which can create structural headwinds for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is decreasing by 15.07% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 11.9%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This means that homes are selling relatively quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing, and may require businesses to provide relocation assistance or other incentives.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks at the 50th percentile, with a composite score of 2.74 out of 5. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require specialized office workers, but less ideal for those that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The city of Jacksonville presents a challenging labor market for businesses, with low unemployment, stagnant wage growth, and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential labor market constraints and affordability challenges, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth and require significant investments in talent attraction and retention strategies. Overall, businesses should carefully weigh these factors before making a location decision in Jacksonville.